

# DPhil Thesis Draft



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A thesis submitted for the degree of  
*Doctor of Philosophy in Materials*

Michaelmas 2021



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# Abbreviations

- CMOS** complementary metal-oxide-semiconductor. 2, 25
- CNT** carbon nanotube. 1, 15, 16, 17, 23, 33, 36
- CNTFET** carbon nanotube field-effect transistor. 16, 17, 19, 21
- CVD** chemical vapour deposition. 2, 3
- DFT** Density Functional Theory. 22
- DIBL** drain induced barrier lowering. 19
- EOT** effective oxide thickness. 20, 21
- ESR** electron-spin resonance. 29
- FET** field-effect transistor. 9, 16, 31
- GNR** graphene nanoribbon. 1, 23, 29, 32, 33, 35
- GNRFET** graphene nanoribbon field-effect transistor. 29
- MOSFET** metal-oxide-semiconductor field-effect transistor. 12, 13, 14, 20, 34
- MW** multi-walled. 15, 36
- NEGF** non-equilibrium Green function. 22
- QD** quantum dot. 36, 38, 39
- SB** Schottky barrier. 16
- SS** Sub-threshold swing. 19, 20, 21
- SW** single-walled. 15



# 1

## Introduction

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In this chapter, I seek to give the motivation and context for this thesis: the investigation of molecular synthesised graphene nanoribbons (GNRs) for use in nanoelectronics. To this end, I will provide a brief introduction of the major all-carbon alternatives already investigated. The chapter is structured as to present first the solid-state crystal properties, and how these lead to unique and different dispersion relations across graphene, carbon nanotubes (CNTs), and GNRs. Secondly, the most pertinent applications—and limitations—in modern electrons are outlined.

## 1.1 Motivation

The widespread shortage of semiconductors begun in the late 2020 has called both major chipmakers and the scientific community to think more deeply and actively to beyond-silicon replacements. For largely over three decades, the main research-driven factor in the transistor industry has been the complementary metal-oxide-semiconductor (CMOS) density scaling; now it is leaving the floor to pursuit short-channel-effects robust materials and which are capable of being integrated in silicon production pipelines.

According to Bloomberg, the basic costs of building a semiconductor factory are around 15 with profit requirements in the order of 3 to sustain market competition and avoid becoming obsolete [1]. These figures are also supported by an analysis done last year by the Boston Consulting Group, which places the investments in R&D (22% of annual semiconductors sales) and capital expenditure (26%) as the highest across all industries [2].

The large market position and capitalisaiton of the major chip makers have persuaded the proposals of integrating graphene in the semiconductor manufacturing cycle. Typically these are split between front- and back-end lines: while the former use temperature as high as 1000 K for activating the dopant process, back-end lines require milder temperatures—approximately 450 K—thus offering the possibility of successfully intergate graphene into the fabrication pipelines. While chemical vapour deposition (CVD) through plasma enhanced techinques has permitted the direct growth of graphene on silicon, the amorphous nature of Si and the presence of defects in the substrates reduce the graphene layer quality.

One possible solution to mitigate these issues would be to directly grown graphene onto the Si substrate. In order to do so, it is required that first the substrate is sputterend with a catalyst, which typically comes in form of Cu particles sputtered in vacuum. The critical step, in this case, is the removal of the metal substrate, as it often requires the use of etchants and high-temperatures, which are unsuitable for back-end lines processing.

Decoupling the growth process from the final substrate offers a second and, often, more valid alternative compared to the direct growth. Graphene is first CVD-grown on Cu or Pt substrate, and then transferred onto the target surface. Describe few transferring method, such as bubble assisted, wet, dry, support-free Whilst suitable mobility values in the order of  $10,000 \text{ cm}^2\text{V}^{-1}\text{s}^{-1}$  have been proved, this process has two major hurdles. Firstly, wafer-scale transferring techniques use polymers to handle graphene. Generally these are all high-molecular-weight polymers, such as PMMA, which are also flexible, to limit the surface tensions on graphene that could cause ripples and folds. Secondly, delaminating the metal substrate leaves contaminants in the graphene layer, causing unwanted doping effects.

While these production and integration approaches are relatively new compared to the traditional silicon electronics, commercial monolayer graphene is nowadays produced by several companies and start-ups, with prices ranging from 15\$/cm<sup>2</sup> (Grolltex) to 195.58\$/cm<sup>2</sup> (2D semiconductors).

## 1.2 Graphene

### 1.2.1 Crystal Structure

Graphene has a hexagonal structure where the carbon atoms are hybridised  $sp^2$ , as detailed by the Pauling theory on chemical bonds. Based on the experimental evidence collected in the last 20 years, the model that seems to best describe the proprieties of graphene is the band-structure Wallace model, which dates back in 1947, and describes graphene as a semimetal with a linear dispersion of the electronic excitations. In the International Table of Crystallography, graphene is included in the symmorphic space group #191, with symmetry  $D_6^1h$  ( $P6/mmm$ ). The triangular lattice is obtained by considering two atoms per unit cell having the respective lattice vectors:

The carbon atoms in graphene form a two-dimensional hexagonal crystal with two atoms per unit cell, as shown in Fig. 1.1:

$$\mathbf{a}_1 = \frac{a}{2}(3, \sqrt{3}), \quad \mathbf{a}_2 = \frac{a}{2}(3, -\sqrt{3}), \quad (1.1)$$

with  $a \approx 1.42$  Å be the carbon-carbon bond length. Each atom belonging to one sublattice, called sublattice A, has three first neighbours belonging to the other sublattice, called sublattice B. With respect to one atom chosen from sublattice A as origin, the position of these first three neighbours in real space are given by:

$$\boldsymbol{\delta}_1 = \frac{a}{2}(1, \sqrt{3}), \quad \boldsymbol{\delta}_2 = \frac{a}{2}(1, -\sqrt{3}), \quad \boldsymbol{\delta}_3 = -a(1, 0), \quad (1.2)$$

The reciprocal-lattice vectors are then given

$$\mathbf{b}_1 = \frac{2\pi}{3a}(1, \sqrt{3}), \quad \mathbf{b}_2 = \frac{2\pi}{3a}(1, -\sqrt{3}), \quad (1.3)$$

In order to define the vertices of the Brillouin zone one has to apply the Bragg condition:

$$2\mathbf{k} \cdot \mathbf{G} = 0 \quad (1.4)$$

where

$$\mathbf{G} = n\mathbf{b}_1 + m\mathbf{b}_2, \quad (1.5)$$

The first amongst these are:

$$\begin{array}{lll} n = \pm 1, & m = 0, & \mathbf{G} = \pm \mathbf{b}_1, \\ n = 0, & m = \pm 1, & \mathbf{G} = \pm \mathbf{b}_2, \\ n = \pm 1, & m = \pm 1, & \mathbf{G} = \pm(\mathbf{b}_1 + \mathbf{b}_2), \end{array}$$

and all these vectors have the same modulus  $|\mathbf{G}| = \frac{4\pi}{3a}$ . By applying Bragg's condition in the first of the three cases we get:

$$\sqrt{3}k_x + k_y = \mp \frac{4\pi}{3a}, \quad (1.6)$$

which gets satisfied by the points:

$$K \equiv \mp \frac{2\pi}{3a} \left( \frac{1}{\sqrt{3}}, 1 \right) \quad (1.7)$$

For the second case one gets:

$$\mp (\sqrt{3}k_x - k_y) = \frac{4\pi}{3a}, \quad (1.8)$$

which gives the points:

$$K' \equiv \pm \frac{2\pi}{3a} \left( \frac{1}{\sqrt{3}}, -1 \right) \quad (1.9)$$

The third and last case gives the point:

$$M \equiv \pm \left( 0, \pm \frac{2\pi}{3a} \right) \quad (1.10)$$

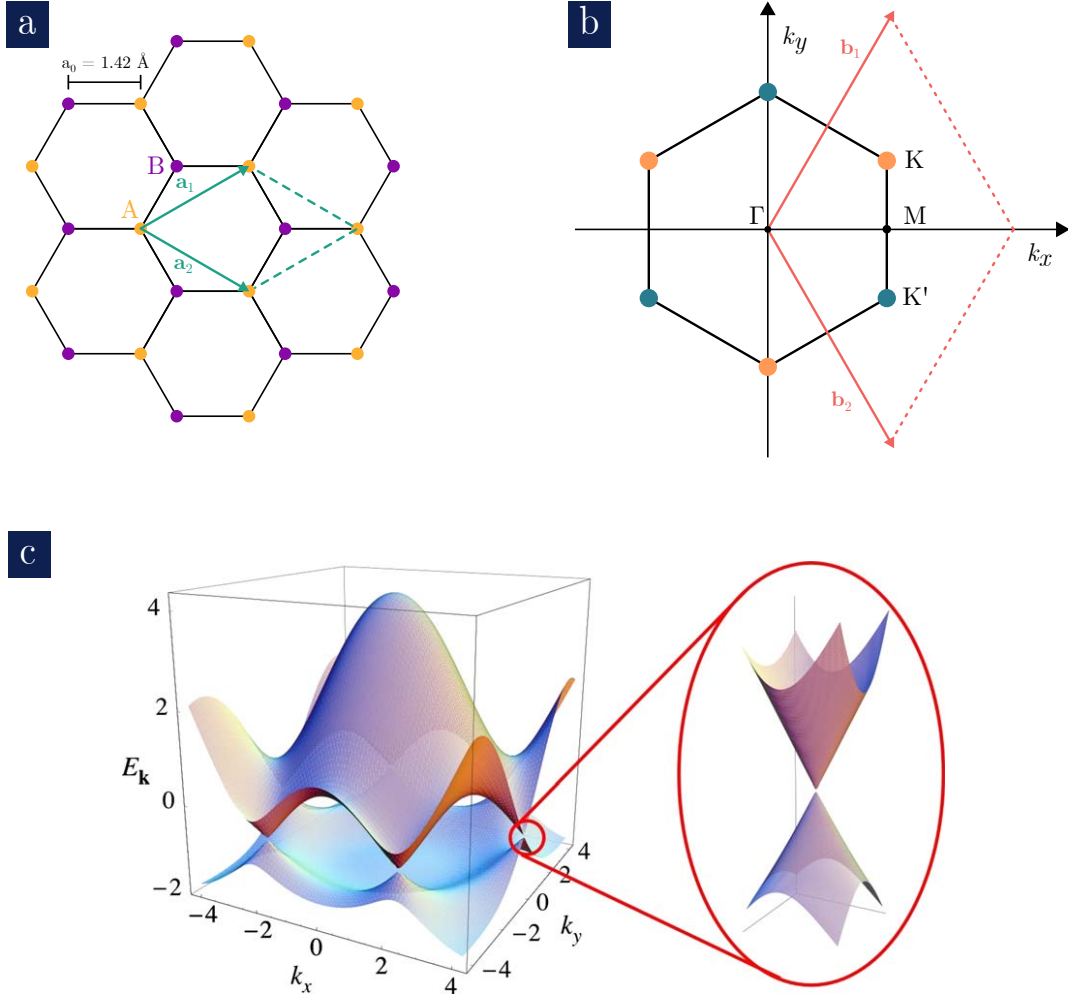
### 1.2.2 Band Structure

The electronic structure of graphene can be model with a tight-binding hamiltonian. Following the second quantization formalism ( $\hbar = 1$  units), the hamiltonian can be written as:

$$\mathcal{H}_{\text{TB}} = -t \sum_{\langle ij \rangle, \sigma} \left( a_{\sigma,i}^\dagger b_{\sigma,j} + \text{H.c.} \right) - t' \sum_{\langle\langle ij \rangle\rangle, \sigma} \left( a_{\sigma,i}^\dagger a_{\sigma,j} + b_{\sigma,i}^\dagger b_{\sigma,j} + \text{H.c.} \right), \quad (1.11)$$

The notation  $\langle ij \rangle$  means that the sum runs over pairs of electrons which are nearest neighbour; similarly, the notation  $\langle\langle ij \rangle\rangle$  specify a summation over the next nearest neighbours; the operators  $a_{i,\sigma}^\dagger$  ( $a_{i,\sigma}$ ) and  $b_{i,\sigma}^\dagger$  ( $b_{i,\sigma}$ ) creates (annihilates) an electron with spin  $\sigma$  ( $\sigma = \uparrow, \downarrow$ ) for atoms on sublattice A and B, respectively. The value of  $t$  which reproduces best experimental result is  $t \approx 2.8$  eV and quantify the nearest-neighbour hopping energy; similarly,  $t'$  denotes the next nearest-neighbour hopping energy. The dispersion energy computed from this model reads:

$$E_{\pm}(\mathbf{k}) = \epsilon_p - t' f(\mathbf{k}) \pm t \sqrt{3 + f(\mathbf{k})}, \quad (1.12)$$



**Figure 1.1:** (a) Honeycomb lattice of graphene. Two non-equivalent carbon atoms A and B in the primitive cells (direct space) are denoted in yellow and purple. The set of possible translations are shown by the lattice vectors  $\mathbf{a}_1, \mathbf{a}_2$  (green arrows). (b) The first Brillouin zone of graphene with vertices  $\mathbf{K}$  (orange) and  $\mathbf{K}'$  (green), and reciprocal-lattice vectors drawn in red. (c) Graphene energy dispersion resulted from Eq. 1.11 (in units of nearest neighbor hopping parameter  $t$ ). The magnification shows one of the Dirac cones, which are located at the  $\mathbf{K}$  and  $\mathbf{K}'$  points, emphasising the linear dispersion relation. Adapted from [3].

with  $f(\mathbf{k})$  defined as:

$$f(\mathbf{k}) = 2 \cos(\sqrt{3}k_y a) + 4 \cos\left(\frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}k_y a\right) \cos\left(\frac{3}{2}k_x a\right). \quad (1.13)$$

Therefore, it is possible to identify an upper ( $\pi^*$ ) band associated with the plus sign and a lower ( $\pi$ ) band described by the minus sign; these are symmetric with respect to the single-particle zero energy. The experimental estimate reported



for next nearest-neighbour hopping energy is  $t' \approx 0.1$  eV thus the asymmetry introduced is small.

If the system is not doped, there is one electron per carbon atom, so two electrons per cell: it follows that the lower band is full and the upper band is empty the upper one is empty. The system is therefore a semi-metal. The peculiarities of the dispersion in graphene become apparent when analysing their trend near the point  $\mathbf{K}$  and  $\mathbf{K}'$ . By taking the positive components for the  $\mathbf{K}$  as define in Eq. 1.7 and expanding the Eq. 1.12 as  $\mathbf{k} = \mathbf{K} + \mathbf{q}$ , with  $|\mathbf{q}| \ll |\mathbf{K}|$ , one gets:

$$E_{\pm}(\mathbf{q}) = \epsilon_p \pm \frac{3at}{2}|\mathbf{q}| \quad (1.14)$$

which is linear in  $\mathbf{q}$ . For intrinsic graphene, at  $T = 0\text{K}$   $E_F = \epsilon_p$ . The Fermi velocity is defined by the usuale relation  $v_F = \frac{1}{\hbar} \left( \frac{dE}{dk} \right)$ , and in graphene  $v_F \simeq 1 \times 10^6 \text{ ms}^{-1} = 0.66 \text{ eV} \times \text{nm} \times \hbar^{-1}$ .

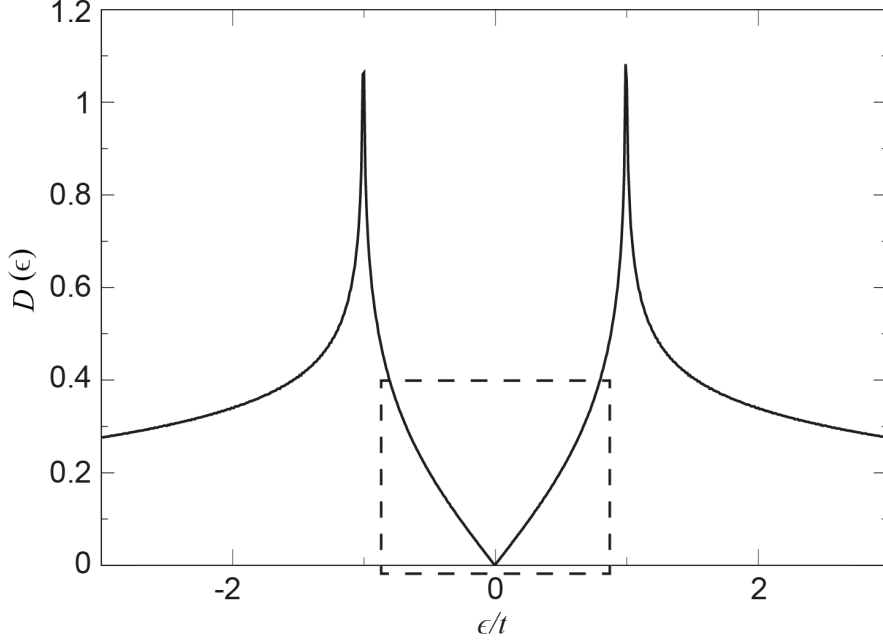
A difference arises in the density of the states, when we limit ourselves to consider those near the Fermi energy. In the case of a two-dimensional electron gas, it is constant. On the contrary for graphene, the density of states per unite cell is:

$$\rho(E) = \frac{2A_{\text{cell}}}{\pi} \frac{|E|}{v_F^2} \quad (1.15)$$

If the graphene is charge-neutral, the DOS has two Van Hove singularities at  $\rho(\omega_{\text{VH}}) = \pm 1 \text{ eV}$  [4]. This behaviour is in stark constrat with the DOS of carbon nanotubes and clean graphene nanoribbons, as they show  $1/\sqrt{E}$  singularities due to the 1D nature, which imposes a quantization perpendicular to the ribbon or tube longitudinal direction. Using the Einstein-Smoluchowski relation  $D = k_B T / \eta = \mu k_B T$  which links an average friction coeafficient  $\eta$  experienced by a flow of semiclassical charge carriers diffusing in a media with coeafficient  $D$ , it is possible to compute the semiclassical conductivity from the DOS as:

$$\sigma_{\text{sc}} = e^2 \rho(E) v(E) \ell_{\text{el}} \quad (1.16)$$

where  $v(E)$  is the carrier velocity,  $\ell_{\text{el}}$  the elastic mean free path, and  $e$  the elementary charge. From Eq. 1.16 and the charge density  $n(E)$ , one can calculate the charge



**Figure 1.2:** Graphene density of states plotted over a wide range of nearest neighbor hopping parameter  $t$ , showing pronounced van Hove singularities for  $\epsilon \sim \pm t$  [3]. The dashed rectangle indicates the almost linear low energy DOS normally spanned in back-gated transport measurements.

mobility, which, at zero temperature, reads:

$$\mu(E) = \frac{\sigma_{sc}}{en} \quad (1.17)$$

Close to the Dirac points, the experimental conductivities lie within  $\approx 2 - 5e^2/h$  range, although the charge mobility can vary due to doping from the electrical contacts and/or the substrate by almost one order magnitude [5, 6].

### 1.2.3 Graphene Transistors

For transistor applications, a material needs a highly conductive on-state and an off-state where the source-drain current  $I_{sd}$  does not flow. For RFs applications, on the other hand, the full speed operation is obtained by operating in the (drain) current saturation regime. Both applications requires a sizeable band gap. Furthermore, the IC scaling trend is often juxtaposed to chip-level issues such as power densities (currently on the order of  $1000 \text{ W/cm}^2$ ), heat generation, and chip temperatures reaching levels that will prevent reliable operations.

In CMOS logic, the charge carriers are accelerated by the electric field  $\mathcal{E}_{\text{sd}}$  between source and drain, thus undergoing five possible sources of scattering: electron–electron scattering, electron–phonon (lattice vibrations), material interfaces, imperfections or impurity atoms. The first two are more fundamentals, while the last three are material-related. The most dominant mechanism through which charge carriers lose net energy is by scattering with phonons, consequently heating up the lattice via Joule heating. For RF applications, on the other hand, heat is produced by the operational frequency at which the carriers operate. Thus, two further requirements are needed: on one hand a good thermal conductivity, but also small heat transfer with the substrate. Clearly trade-offs are here necessary.

The 2020 International Roadmap for Devices and Systems - which has replaced since 2017 the International Roadmap for Semiconductors - dedicates ample attention to graphene in its report *Beyond CMOS*, in which technologies and semiconductor materials to complement and replace Si are considered. The race to scale the channel in a field-effect transistor (FET) still motivates a significant effort on introducing high-mobility channel materials, since the carrier mobility is an appropriate parameter to address carrier transport even in nanometer FETs [7]. In fact, most of the early excitements in using graphene as channel material in a standard FET technology were sparked by considering the outstanding mobility values reported since its discovery.

At 290 K, the intrinsic mobility  $\mu_e^{\text{in}}$  of graphene is exceptionally high. The first data were the one obtained in 2004 on large-area graphene, showing an electron mobility  $\mu_e^{\text{in}} \approx 10,000 \text{ cm}^2 \text{V}^{-1} \text{s}^{-1}$  [8]. Further studies have demonstrated mobilities spanning between  $\mu^{\text{in}} \sim 3000 - 12000 \text{ cm}^2 \text{V}^{-1} \text{s}^{-1}$  for carrier concentrations  $n \approx 1 - 0.1 \times 10^{12} \text{ cm}^{-2}$ , with low-field field-effect mobility<sup>†</sup> ( $\mu = (1/C_g)(\partial\sigma/\partial V_{\text{gs}})$ ) that is constant over a quite wide range of  $n$  (yielding in this case  $\mu_h \approx 1900 \text{ cm}^2 \text{V}^{-1} \text{s}^{-1}$  and  $\mu_e \approx 1800 \text{ cm}^2 \text{V}^{-1} \text{s}^{-1}$  for the low  $n$  region) [9].

The mobility is limited by different factors such as scattering by charged impurities or defects and electron-phonon scattering. In very clean and suspended

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<sup>†</sup>This differs from the Drude ( $\mu_{\text{Drude}} = \sigma/ne$ ) and Hall ( $\mu_{\text{Hall}} = -\sigma_e R_H$ ) mobilities.

samples (where the underling  $\text{SiO}_2$  substrate has been etched away) the mean free path  $l$  increases by almost two order of magnitude, becoming comparabe to the device size, an indication that the ballistic transport regime is reached

Later in 2008 [10] and 2013 [11], higher mobility values were reported:  $\approx 120,000 \text{ cm}^2\text{V}^{-1}\text{s}^{-1}$  at 240 K and  $\approx 1,000,000 \text{ cm}^2\text{V}^{-1}\text{s}^{-1}$  at 4 K. The reason for these higher values was attributed to the use of suspended graphene rather onto substrate, where surface effects inevitably affect the carrier dynamics. At the same time, results ( $\approx 120,000 \text{ cm}^2\text{V}^{-1}\text{s}^{-1}$ ) obtained at room temperature with graphene onto a single-layer of hexagonal boron nitride (hBN) [12] and sandwiched between two hBN layer [11] have suggested that this flat and inert materials can be act as a excellent passivation film for graphene devices.

One of the figure of merit often taken into account for addressing logic applications for a materials is the ratio between the on-state current and the off-state current. The so called on-off ratio  $I_{\text{on}}/I_{\text{off}}$  has to be in the range  $10^4$ – $10^7$ . While the  $I_{\text{on}}$  is not directly related to the band gap  $E_g$ , it is possible to link the value of  $I_{\text{off}}$  with the  $E_g$ .

In an metal–semiconductor junction (M/S), the current is built by the majority of the carriers, these being electrons or holes for  $n$ -type or  $p$ -type semiconductors. Most of the graphene–semiconductor junctions formed during experiments have typical dopant concentration  $N \leq 10^{17} \text{ cm}^{-3}$ . The  $I - V$  characteristics of M/S junctions with such dopant concentrations are well reproduced by the thermoionic emission theory. If we then exclude other possible conduction mechanisms (standard and thermoionic field emission, generation/recombination, diffusion of electron, injection of holes and leakage current), the  $I_{\text{off}}$  becomes proportional to the barrier the electrons have to overcome from the semiconductor to the metal, namely

$$I_{\text{off}} \propto \exp\{(e\beta\phi_B)\}. \quad (1.18)$$

where  $e$  is the electron charge,  $\phi_B$  is the Schottky barrier height, and  $\beta = k_B T$ . If we assume that the work function of graphene and the metal are the same, then  $\phi_B = E_g/2$ , where  $E_g$  is the band gap energy originating from the difference of the

|                                                                   | Direct Gap |      |      | Indirect Gap |        |          |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|------|------|--------------|--------|----------|
|                                                                   | InP        | Si   | Ge   | GaAs         | InAs   | Graphene |
| $a_{\text{lattice}}$ (Å)                                          | 5.87       | 5.43 | 5.65 | 5.65         | 6.06   | 2.46     |
| $E_g$ (eV)                                                        | 1.35       | 1.12 | 0.66 | 1.42         | 0.36   | 0        |
| $\mu$ (cm <sup>2</sup> V <sup>-1</sup> s <sup>-1</sup> ) at 300 K | 2800       | 1400 | 3900 | 4600         | 16,000 | 200,000  |
| $v_{\text{sat}}$ (10 <sup>7</sup> cm s <sup>-1</sup> )            | 2.2        | 1    | 0.6  | 2.2          | 4.0    | >5       |
| DOS ( $m^*/m_0$ )                                                 | 0.077      | 1.08 | 0.56 | 0.067        | 0.023  | 0        |
| $\epsilon_r$                                                      | 12.4       | 11.9 | 16.0 | 13.1         | 14.6   | 2.4      |
| $\kappa$ (W m <sup>-1</sup> K <sup>-1</sup> )                     | 68         | 150  | 60.2 | 46           | 27     | 5000     |

**Table 1.1:** Differences between the main semiconductors used in modern digital electronics and graphene.

work function of graphene and the metal; thus, the on–off ratio can be estimated from the useful proportionality [13]:

$$\frac{I_{\text{on}}}{I_{\text{off}}} \propto \exp\left\{\frac{E_g}{2k_B T}\right\}, \quad (1.19)$$

where the thermal energy  $k_B T$  and the bandgap are both expressed in meV. While for high frequency applications the on–off ratio is of minor importance, several references in literature report suitable values for CMOS bandgap should fall in a range between 300 and 500 meV [14, 15].

Hysteresis between the forward and reverse sweeps have been reported depending on the sweeping rate and range [16], and attributed mainly to charge trapping in silanol groups (Si–OH), mediated and assisted by surface-bound H<sub>2</sub>O molecules [17]. Despite the usefulness for its proof-of-concept purposes, back-gate devices suffered from parasitic capacitances, making impossible further integration with other components. Alternatives geometries have since then been explored, in order to increase the carriers mobility, to decrease contact resistances and parasitic

capacitances, and to avoid Schottky barriers formation between the graphene and the semiconductor. Top-gate devices have been the first to chronologically appear in the literature. Back then in 2007, Lemme and co workers used a stack of SiO<sub>2</sub> (20 nm), Ti (10 nm), and Au (100 nm) as top gate for modulating the current inside a large-area graphene channel transistor obtained by the exfoliation method [18]. Whilst the gate characteristics exhibit a similar trend of the characteristics (the top gate reduces the back-gate current modulation, lowering the drain current by one order of magnitude) and the hysteresis, weak current saturation at high drain-source bias have been reported [19]. This effect seem due to a partial charge pinning at the contacts at high back-gate voltages [20] and carrier drift velocity eventually saturating due to optical-phonon scattering [21]. Top-gated graphene metal–oxide–semiconductor field-effect transistors (MOSFETs) with CVD and epitaxial graphene have been also made [22, 23]; SiO<sub>2</sub>, Al<sub>2</sub>O<sub>3</sub>, and HfO<sub>2</sub> have been used as top-gate dielectric.

However, despite the improvements obtained with a top gate, most graphene MOSFET with large-area graphene channels show on–off switching ratios of less than 10 at room temperature [14], much too little for complex logic circuits.

In 2012, Mehr *et al.* proposed a vertical arrangement of emitter, base, and collector similar to the original vacuum triode, where graphene plays the base role and electrons travel vertically rather than transversely. When the device is in the ON state, the electrons tunnel with a Fowler-Nordheim tunnelling mechanism:

$$I \propto \left(\frac{V_{sd}}{d}\right)^2 \exp\left\{-\frac{\alpha d}{V_{sd}}\right\}, \quad (1.20)$$

through the emitter–base layer (of thickness  $d$ ); ON/OFF ratios of the order of 10<sup>4</sup> have been demonstrated using graphene between two h-BN layers [24] and using WeS<sub>2</sub>–graphene [25] heterostructures.

Solution methods have also been explored, in which graphene is dropcasted on top of a semiconducting wafer, and then spin-coated [26]. The main difficulties arise when attempting to quantify the structure and the quality of the deposited graphene, and not many methods can guarantee a good dispersion in organic solvents [27].

Simpler ways to obtain graphene oxide in solution have been reported [28], but once deposited, graphene oxide needs to be reduced for obtaining pure graphene – low mobility values (up to, at best,  $1000 \text{ cm}^2 \text{ V}^{-1} \text{ s}^{-1}$ ) caused by defects during the fabrication steps have discouraged further investigations along this direction.

Yet in spite of the very different dc behavior compared to the most used semiconductors in digital electronics, graphene FETs have reported good performance in terms of high-frequency applications. This comparison is made by measuring each system's frequency response, its output signal strength when it is given a particular input signal: features such as ballistic transport, linear current-voltage characteristics, high transconductance, and very high ( $> 10^8 \text{ A cm}^{-2}$ ) sustainable currents are all ideal features for analog/RF applications [21, 29].

The primary means of estimating frequency response is through the evaluation of two transistor characteristic frequencies, namely cutoff  $f_T$  and maximum of oscillations  $f_{\text{max}}$ . The former indicates how quickly a signal can travel from the gate to the drain of the device, and it is usually determined when the small-signal current gain drops to unity, while the latter is measured when the power gain decreases to unity [14]. The frequency response depends inversely on gate length and proportionally to the transconductance, which is loosely proportional to mobility. Thus, reducing the gate length and using higher mobility materials are valid approaches to increase the device operational speed [30]. In this context, many research groups have successfully demonstrated RF capabilities with gapless graphene channels MOSFETs.

The first device with cutoff frequency  $f_T$  in the GHz range was reported in late 2008, and was fabricated by exfoliated graphene deposited on top of high-resistivity Si substrate, with 30-nm-thick top-gate  $\text{HfO}_2$  dielectric and 500 nm of gate length [29]. Despite a measured  $f_T \approx 14.7 \text{ GHz}$ , it was argued that large contact resistances and gate length were the main responsible of poor performance  $f_{\text{max}} < 1 \text{ GHz}$ .

The following year, Pd/Au contacts and 12-nm-thick  $\text{Al}_2\text{O}_3$  were employed in a 350-nm-gate [31]. While the cutoff frequency improved up to  $f_T \approx 50 \text{ GHz}$ , little gains in terms of  $f_{\text{max}}$  were obtained of only 2 GHz. In general, limited

performance in  $f_{\max}$  represents a major issue as for most RF applications  $f_T$  is less important than  $f_{\max}$ .

It was only after two years that an increase of one order of magnitude both in the cutoff and the maximum frequency of oscillation was demonstrated [23]. The device was realised with epitaxially-grown on silicon carbide (SiC) graphene MOSFET having 240 nm of gate length, with Ti/Pd/Au for contacts and 10-nm-thick  $\text{HfO}_2$  of insulating layer on top gates. Highest frequency as well as  $f_T \approx 100$  GHz and  $f_{\max} \approx 14$  GHz were measured, exceeding any device then present. The authors also argued that since  $f_{\max}$  is strongly correlated to device layout and parasitic resistances originating from the metallic contacts, viable ways to improve this parameter would be a partial passivation of the metal contacts and a multi-finger gate layout

These performance were soon followed later that year by a 144-nm-length gate device with  $f_T \approx 300$  GHz using mechanically exfoliated graphene and  $\text{Co}_2\text{Si}-\text{Al}_2\text{O}_3$  nanowire as self-aligned multi top-gates [32]. This result was also corroborated by comparing it with the projected value using the relation that links dc transconductance and gate capacitance with the cutoff frequency when total input parasitic capacitance is negligible, namely  $f_T = g_m/(2\pi C_g)$  [33]. The authors did not report the power  $G_{\max}^{1/2}$  but only the current  $|h_{21}|$  gain, thus hampering an evaluation of  $f_{\max}$ , but in 2012 a similar proposal was advanced by Cheng *et al.*, where Au/Ti/ $\text{Al}_2\text{O}_3$  gate stacks were employed in self-aligned transistors [34]. Despite the improvements reported ( $f_T \approx 427$  GHz for a channel length of 67 nm) respect to CVD graphene transistors with comparable channel length,  $f_{\max}$  decreased down to 8 GHz when the length was shrunk down to 46 nm, showing the key role played by gate and parasitic resistances at high frequency.

To further improve the power gain, works on the saturation behavior of short channel graphene transistor were also conducted by IBM in 2012, by using CVD graphene grown on a Cu foil and then transferred on diamond-like and SiC substrates [35]. These are appealing because high-quality wafers are available, thus making a scale up of graphene arrays relatively straightforward. Since the work function of graphene is  $\phi^g = 4.5$  eV and  $\phi^{4\text{H-SiC}} = 3.7$  eV, this means that  $\Delta\phi^{g-4\text{H-SiC}} = 0.8$



eV, thus  $n$ -doping graphene [36]. Very cleverly, the authors then used plasma-enhanced CVD silicon nitride as an intrinsic p-type gate dielectric, counterbalancing the  $n$ -doped graphene channels. Encouraging performance at high speed were not only measured in good cutoff frequencies ( $f_T \approx 350$  GHz), but also in a factor of 2 improvement of  $f_{\max}$  ( $\approx 40$  GHz). To the best of my knowledge, the current graphene transistor power gain record of about 70 GHz was obtained in 2013 by using (000-1) carbon-terminated surface of SiC instead of the (0001) Si one, indicating the contact resistance  $R_c$  between Pd/Au contacts and graphene as key responsible for the high  $f_{\max}$ .

While these results have aligned graphene MOSFET with the main solid-state competitors – such as GaAS pHEMT, InP HEMT and Si MOSFET – in terms of  $f_T$ , the performance in terms of  $f_{\max}$  are off by about one [37, 38] or two orders of magnitude [39]. In literature, one of the often cited fundamental reason for this behaviour is the poor drain saturation current in graphene, which ultimately depends on the missing bandgap of the channel. Graphene-derived materials such as nanoribbons and carbon nanotubes MOSFET could then, given their intrinsic semiconducting nature, represent a possible solution to this problem.

## 1.3 Carbon-Nanotube

### 1.3.1 Crystal and Band Structure

This crystalline form of carbon can be considered as a rolled up sheet of graphene and comes in two major flavours: single-walled (SW) and multi-walled (MW). CNTs display an electronic band gap which depends on the chirality and the diameter of the nanotube [40]. Having defined two unit vectors in the real space,  $\mathbf{a}_1$  and  $\mathbf{a}_2$ , a CNT can be described by the linear combination of these with integers coefficients  $(m, n)$ . Based on the values of  $m$  and  $n$ , CNTs can be metallic, quasi-metallic ( $m - n$  is a multiple of 3, with  $m \cdot n \neq 0$  and  $m \neq n$ ), and semiconducting for the majority of the remaining cases – exceptions due to the curvature (spin-orbit couplings) in small-diameter tubes are also known [41]. Thus, a quantization of the electronic states in the circumferential direction is resulted when the nanotube diameter  $d_{\text{CNT}}$

is between 0.8 and 2.5 nm. Each of these substates is called subband and are determined by the periodic boundary condition. Having defined a circumferential wave vector  $\mathbf{k}_c$  such that  $\mathbf{k}_c \cdot \mathbf{c} = k_c |c| = k_c \pi d_{\text{CNT}} = 2\pi\nu$ , for  $\nu$  integer, it is possible from this relation to draw parallel lines in the first Brillouin zone of graphene. If the subband intersect one of the  $\mathbf{K}$  points, then the resulting nanotube will have no energy gap and thus exhibit metallic properties (this condition is realised by having  $m = n$  for the coefficients of the chiral vector). If none of the subbands pass through  $\mathbf{K}$  then the resulting CNT will be semiconducting, having a  $E_g$  proportional to the smallest distance between a  $\mathbf{K}$  point and the subband lines:

$$E_g = 2 \left( \frac{\partial E}{\partial k} \right) \frac{k_c}{3} = \frac{2}{3} \hbar v_F \frac{2\pi}{|c|} = \frac{4}{3} \hbar v_F \frac{1}{d_{\text{CNT}}} \approx \frac{0.7}{d_{\text{CNT}}} \quad (1.21)$$

where  $v_F = 8 \times 10^5 \text{ m s}^{-1}$  is the Fermi velocity,  $E_g$  is expressed in eV, and  $d_{\text{CNT}}$  is expressed in nm.

### 1.3.2 Carbon Nanotube Field-Effect Transistors

#### General Operation

The modulation of a CNT channel by a gate-induced field was realised in the 1998 by the group of Cees Dekkar. These early FETs were fabricated by using doped silicon substrate as a gate to modulate the energy bands, separated from the nanotube by thermally-grown  $\text{SiO}_2$  oxide acting as dielectric. For contacting the nanotube, metal conctats were employed.

Since then, a great variety of carbon nanotube field-effect transistor (CNTFET) structures and geometries have been demonstrated, and can be essentially classified in devices with or without a spacer. where the spacer length  $L_{\text{spr}}$  is the distance between the gated channel and the source/drain metal conctacts. Given that the nanotubes are intrinsically semiconducting, in spacer-less devices charge carriers are not induced in the channel by the gate-field but are injected from the contacts: the role of the gate is to lower the thermal barrier in the channel, thus allowing a tunnelling through the Schottky barrier (SB) at the source. In this scenario, a critical role for the CNTFET performance is played by the metal work function  $\phi^{\text{M}}$ .

CNTFETs with spacers, on the other hand, are less limited by the injection at the junction source–CNT, as they are regulated by the modulating effect played by in the channel as in conventional. Since the carrier barrier injection at the drain is large, device with spacers have been proved to be more resistant to ambipolar conduction. In Table 1.2 an overview of gated-spacer (top and bottom) devices is reported.

### Contacts

One of the principal issues when study the interface metal–CNT is the role played by carbon and metal atoms at the interface. Solid-state semiconductors have dangling bonds at the surface, leading to Fermi level pinning, meaning that the variation of the band bending is independent of the work function of the metal, even when this is large. Since the ideal structure of CNTs has no open bonds, no pinning of the metal Fermi level to mid-gap states occurs, thus legitimating the study of different work functions for maximising performance and tuning polarity. Many metals have been studied for contacting CNTs. Interestingly, it has been demonstrated that Pd ( $\phi^{\text{Pd}} = 5.22 - -5.60$ ) builds an almost ideal *p*-channel contact to the valence band of CNTs. Despite having a larger workfunction ( $\phi^{\text{Pt}} \approx 5.65$  eV) than Pd, Pt provides very poor contacts due to the physical wetting of the metal on the nanotube.

| <i>Device type</i> | $I_{\text{on}}/I_{\text{off}}$ | $SS$<br>(mV/dec) | $g_{\text{mt}}$<br>( $\mu\text{S cm}^{-1}$ ) | $L_{\text{ch}}$<br>(nm) | $f_T$ [ $f_{\text{max}}$ ]<br>(GHz) | Ref. |
|--------------------|--------------------------------|------------------|----------------------------------------------|-------------------------|-------------------------------------|------|
| Bottom gate        | $10^4$                         | 94               | $\sim 40$                                    | 9                       | —                                   | [42] |
|                    | $10^5$                         | $\sim 85$        | 40                                           | 15                      | —                                   | [43] |
|                    | $10^5$                         | $\sim 85$        | 20                                           | 20                      | —                                   | [43] |
|                    | $10^5$                         | 60               | 20                                           | 200                     | —                                   | [44] |
|                    | $10^5$                         | $\sim 63$        | —                                            | 200                     | —                                   | [45] |
|                    | $10^4$                         | 80               | 50                                           | 240                     | —                                   | [46] |
|                    | —                              | —                | 143                                          | 800                     | [1]                                 | [47] |
|                    | $10^4$                         | —                | —                                            | 1,500                   | 1.5 – 3.0                           | [48] |
|                    | —                              | 70               | $12^\dagger$                                 | 2,000*                  | —                                   | [49] |
|                    | $10^8$                         | —                | —                                            | $< 10,000^*$            | —                                   | [50] |
|                    | —                              | —                | - 500                                        | —                       | 30                                  | [51] |
| Top gate           | $10^6$                         | —                | $20^\dagger$                                 | 80                      | —                                   | [52] |
|                    | 2                              | —                | $\sim 50$                                    | 100                     | 25                                  | [53] |
|                    | 50                             | —                | 310                                          | 100                     | $\sim 70$ [80]                      | [54] |
|                    | —                              | —                | 0.3                                          | 210                     | —                                   | [55] |
|                    | $10^5$                         | —                | 33.5                                         | 85,000                  | —                                   | [56] |

**Table 1.2:** Figures of merit for a few CNFET reported in literature.  $S$ : subthreshold swing;  $g_m$ : intrinsic transconductances;  $L_{ch}$ : channel length;  $\mu$ : carriers mobility

$^\dagger$ Normalized by the tube width.

<sup>1</sup> Referred to the gated length of a nanotube.

<sup>2</sup> For the n-type transistor, whereas 10  $\mu\text{S}$  were measured for the p-type.

| <i>Device type</i> | $I_{\text{on}}$<br>(A) | $I_{\text{off}}$<br>(A) | $I_{\text{on}}/I_{\text{off}}$ | $g_{\text{mt}}$<br>( $\mu\text{S}$ ) | $SS$<br>(mV/dec) |
|--------------------|------------------------|-------------------------|--------------------------------|--------------------------------------|------------------|
| Conventional       | $1.41 \times 10^{-5}$  | $4.06 \times 10^{-10}$  | $3.4 \times 10^4$              | 29                                   | 99.6             |
| Partial S/D-doped  | $1.50 \times 10^{-5}$  | $2.33 \times 10^{-8}$   | $6.4 \times 10^2$              | 63.6                                 | 93.1             |
| Schottky-Barrier   | $3.26 \times 10^{-6}$  | $2.31 \times 10^{-8}$   | $1.41 \times 10^2$             | 19.6                                 | 109.8            |
| Tunnel             | $5.53 \times 10^{-6}$  | $1.16 \times 10^{-8}$   | $4.76 \times 10^2$             | 13                                   | 107.9            |

**Table 1.3:** Comparative simulation for the four major type of CNFETs as reported in [57]. These results are obtained by setting  $V_{\text{sd}} = 0.5$  V.

### ***n*-Type CNTFETs**

In a *n*-type CNTFETs the injection of electrons is favoured over the holes. Given that  $\phi^{\text{CNT}} \approx 4.7$  eV and with an average  $E_g \approx 0.6$  eV, it is possible to configure *n*-type channel with nanotube by either doping the spacer region or by using a metal with lower work function. One of the main drawbacks of doping is the challenge to keep it under control: instability in air, low consistency, variability to temperature variations, are amongst the most frequent scenarios. The other issue in working with low work function metals as contacts is the high tendency to oxidize. A simple and effective workaround to this is to use high work function metals to cap the contact metals, passivating the contact surface tendency to destabilise in air. One example of high performance *n*-type device was obtained by using Y contacts, achieving an Sub-threshold swing (SS) of 73 mV/dec, mobility of  $5100 \text{ cm V}^{-2} \text{ s}^{-1}$ , and drain induced barrier lowering (DIBL) of  $105 \text{ mV V}^{-1}$  [58].

### **Scaling**

While Si technology was for long time questioned whether it could work below 10-nm of channel length, recent impressive technological developments from the industry have proved not only its feasibility but also a widespread commercial application (currently modern laptop employ the 5-nm technology). Nevertheless, the interest in Si scalability has been always a crucial starting point for exploring different technologies and materials capable of overcoming short-channel effects (threshold voltage roll-off, off-state leakage current, channel length modulation are just a few of the problematics).

In carbon nanotubes transistors a crucial and important – but somehow overlooked difference – is the difference between the two critical lengths for scaling, which are the contact length ( $L_c$ ) and the channel length ( $L_{\text{ch}}$ ). Aggressive scaling for the channel length generally leads to lose control of the band bending through the gate: intuitively, by shrinking the channel length the electric field generated by the source contact will be felt more and more by the charge carriers. The argument here is that carbon nanotubes offer, however, a good enough platform for such

scaling given by the ultrathin hollow structure (recall an effective wall thickness about  $d_{\text{CNT}} \approx 0.68 \text{ \AA}$ ). On the other hand, this could be a double edge-sword. The effective carrier mass in nanotubes is  $m_{\text{CNT}}^* = (0.228 \pm 0.129)m_0$  [59], thus potentially leading to tunnelling current from source to drain: this effect can be appreciate by an increase in the SS and the OFF current.

One of the first few systematic study on channel length scaling effects was conducted by Franklin *et al.* in 2010 through a series of measurements on nanotubes with relatively small diameters ( $1.1 \text{ nm} < d_{\text{CNT}} < 1.3 \text{ nm}$ ) by using local bottom gates covered with 2 nm effective oxide thickness (EOT) of  $\text{HfO}_2$  [60]. A consistent trend was observed when the channel length was scaled down more than two orders of magnitude (from 3  $\mu\text{m}$  to 15 nm), both in the values of  $V_{\text{th}}$  and  $SS$  ( $-0.5 \pm 0.2 \text{ V}$  and 90 mV/dec, respectively). The authors reported also encouraging figures on the transconductance  $g_m$ .

In a standard MOSFET, the transconductance is the change in the drain current divided by the amount varied in the gate/source voltage  $V_{\text{gs}}$  when the drain/source voltage ( $V_{\text{ds}}$ ) is kept constant. Typical values of  $g_m$  for a small-signal field effect transistor are between 1 and 30  $\text{mS}\mu\text{m}^{-1}$ . In a n-channel (nMOS) FET with threshold voltage  $V_{\text{th}}$ , the drain current at a certain  $V_{\text{gs}}$  in saturation mode (so when  $V_{\text{th}} > V_{\text{gs}} - V_{\text{sd}}$ ) is given by:

$$I_{\text{sd}} = \frac{1}{2}\mu_n C_{\text{ox}} \frac{W}{L} (V_{\text{gs}} - V_{\text{th}})^2, \quad (1.22)$$

where  $\mu_n$  is the electron mobility,  $C_{\text{ox}}$  is the gate oxide capacitance,  $W$  and  $L$  are the gate width and length, respectively. It is possible to work out the value of  $g_m$  by using the Shichman–Hodges model and assuming that the threshold voltage  $V_{\text{th}}$  is a device constant, such that  $V_{\text{ov}} = V_{\text{gs}} - V_{\text{th}}$ :

$$g_m = \frac{\partial I_{\text{sd}}}{\partial V_{\text{gs}}} = \frac{2 I_{\text{sd}}}{V_{\text{ov}}}, \quad (1.23)$$

Here  $V_{\text{ov}}$  is the so called *overdrive voltage* and has the physical meaning of being the voltage above the threshold voltage of the MOSFET. It is useful in the designing

phase of a transistor and elegantly links the drain current with a voltage: in fact, by rearranging Eq. 1.22 and identify  $k_n = \mu_n C_{\text{ox}} \frac{W}{L}$  one gets:

$$I_{\text{sd}} = \frac{1}{2} k_n V_{\text{ov}}^2 \implies V_{\text{ov}} = \sqrt{\frac{2I_{\text{sd}}}{k_n}} \quad (1.24)$$

The usefulness for this equation is that the relation expressed in terms of overdrive voltage rather than threshold voltage holds both in the  $n$  and in the  $p$  case. Some reference numbers:  $V_{\text{ov}}$  is typically set at about 70–200 mV for the 65 nm technology node (with  $I_{\text{sd}} = 1.13 \text{ mA } \mu\text{m}^{-1}$  of width) with value of  $g_{\text{m}} \approx 11 - 32 \text{ mS } \mu\text{m}^{-1}$ . In their work, Franklin *et al.* achieved transconductance peak up to  $40 \text{ } \mu\text{S } \mu\text{m}^{-1}$  for a CNTFET with 15 nm of channel length, corresponding to values of  $g_{\text{m}}$  between approximately  $91 - 110 \text{ } \mu\text{S } \mu\text{m}^{-1}$ , thus meeting the requirements for being compatible with the Si technology.

The first CNTFET in which  $L_{\text{ch}}$  was scaled below 10 nm came two years later, again by Franklin *et al.* [42]. By using a CNT with  $d_{\text{CNT}} \approx 1.3 \text{ nm} \pm 0.2 \text{ nm}$  and  $E_g \approx 0.62 \text{ eV} \pm 0.1 \text{ eV}$  contacted through local bottom gates, they manage to scale down the  $L_{\text{ch}} = 9 \text{ nm}$ . The EOT was reduced to  $\approx 0.65 \text{ nm}$  to achieve a better electrostatic coupling with the nanotube.

The authors reported an increase on the minimum current as  $L_{\text{ch}}$  decreases from 320 nm to 9 nm, attributed to a back-injection of the carriers into the conduction band from the drain, while the on-current approached the ballistic value for  $L_{\text{ch}} \leq 41 \text{ nm}$  [60]. Impressive switching behaviour, with SS about 94 mV/dec, was measured, thus far outperforming any silicon-based of that time. based on previous results [60], the authors claimed the possibility of lowering the SS and the off-current at minimal cost to  $I_{\text{on}}$  by reducing the diameter of the nanotubes.

## Contact Length Scaling

MOSFET devices, when shrunk down to the nanoscale, need to consider not only  $L_{\text{ch}}$  but also the length of the nanotube with the source and drain,  $L_{\text{c}}$ . The first study to address the impact of contact scaling in CNTFETs revealed the  $L_{\text{c}}$  to be inversely dependent on the channel length. Initial theoretical attempts to describe

this trend using dipole theories were started following the results obtained by the group of Hongjie Dai, where they showed it is possible to recover a perfect ohmic contact – thus accessing the ballistic transport regime – even with a semiconducting nanotube, which were at the time notorious of suffering several Schottky barriers effects (tunnelling and thermoionic emission).

Further investigations using more sophisticated techniques such as Density Functional Theory (DFT) coupled with the non-equilibrium Green function (NEGF) were employed to consider not only different contact geometries, but mostly to clarify the role in the chemical bonds formed between the metal to carbon structures, or in some combination of metal-/carbon-dependent interfacial charging properties. In particular, Cuniberti and coworkers addressed the chemisorption problem of carbon nanotubes with different electrodic surfaces. Chemisorption consists of the creation of a chemical bond between the atom deposited on a substrate (adatom) and its surface. The bonding leads to changes in the local density of states that produce specific alteration of the surface properties. They considered metal surfaces (such as Ni and Ti) inducing a chemical reaction with the carbon structure (chemisorption), elements such as Pd, Pt, Cr and Sc which interact weakly with the nanotube band structure leaving it unchanged, and surfaces which interact strongly through metallization and/or hybridisation of the  $\pi$  orbitals of the nanotube (Cu, Au, and Rh).

Low-ohmic contact scaling trends were found when using weakly and intermediate interacting metallic surfaces, while they envisioned optimal contact length scaling with metals such as Cu and Rh. While Rh contacts would be unaffordable at large scale due to manufacturing costs, it is well known that Cu presents ill-defined native oxide issues when used under ambient conditions, causing scattering at their surfaces and grain boundaries, thus hampering good electrical contacts with external probes. Recently, it has been advanced graphene as interlayer between the metal contact and the nanotube: the idea would be to have a work function closer to the nanotube one in order to avoid the level pinning effects due to gap states and interface contaminations.



## 1.4 Graphene Nanoribbons

Amongst the wide variety of carbon alternatives explored in the last two decades, GNRs have certainly acquired a lot of interests. Amongst the perks, chemical synthesis of GNRs is now cost effective, they have comparable electrical performance (small effective mass, high charge mobility, and high saturation velocity) compared with the CNTs, without the need to separate metallic from semiconducting GNRs, and they can be easily tailored through chemical synthesis [61, 62].

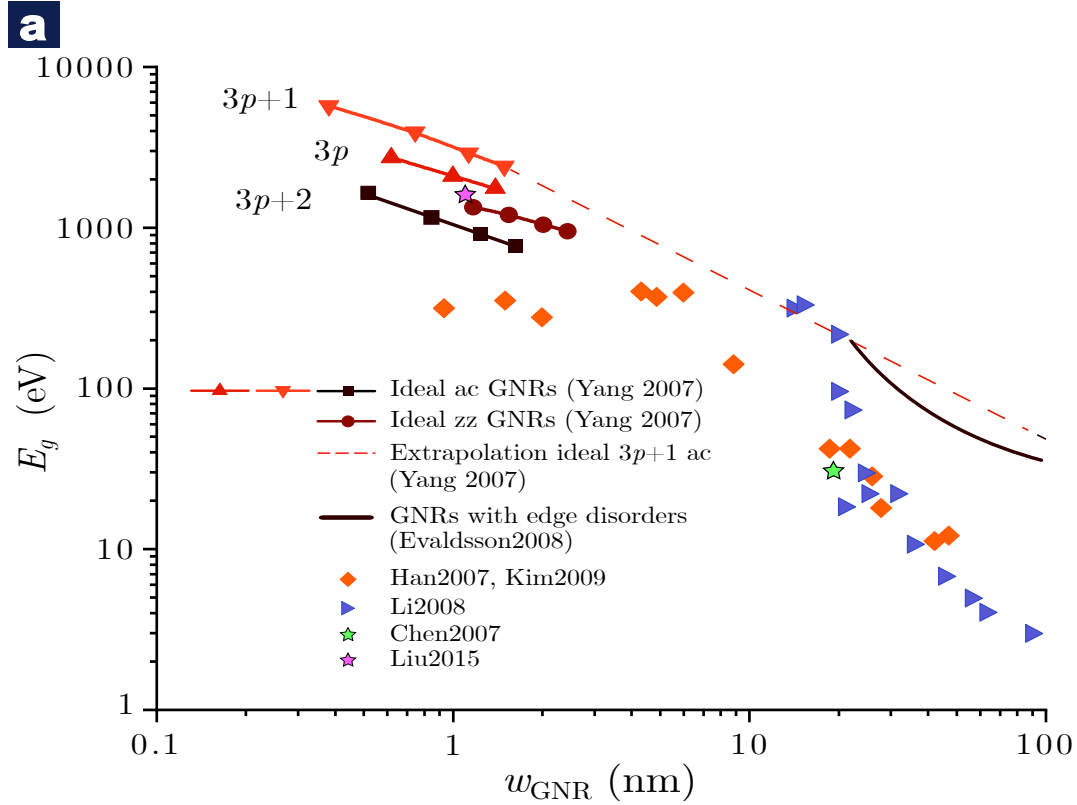
As in the case of CNTs, confining large-area graphene carries into narrow stripes leads to a quasi-1D system exhibiting a tunable bandgap determined not only by the ribbon width  $w_{\text{GNR}}$ , but also by the edge structure [63, 64]. Logic applications, as mentioned in Sec. 1.2, require two well-defined voltage states, which in turn they depend on the current flowing through the semiconducting channel; by considering  $E_g$  within the 300 – 500 meV range, the figure (place the bandgap figure here) gives an indication circa suitable ribbon widths, which would lie within the sub-5 nm regime [65].

### 1.4.1 Crystal and Band Structure

Historically, a first classification of graphene nanoribbons was derived by grouping the edge structures into Armchair-GNRs (AGNRs) and Zigzag-GNRs (ZGNRs). Following the success of chemical routes in producing GNRs, various kind of edges have come to light, e.g., cove, fjord, chiral, and all these can be regarded as combination of AGNRs and ZGNRs Figure.

Initial bandgap estimations through DFT calculations reported values between 2.5 and 0.5 eV. The inclusion of electronic correlation, however, becomes crucial for ultra-narrow ( $< 5$  nm) ribbon [63, 66] and more accurate estimates derived by the group of Steven Louie based on the  $GW$  approximation reported a wider range of energy gaps from 5.5 to 1 eV.

These calculations have shown that, as rule of thumb, AGNRs can be both semi-conducting and metallic, while ZGNRs should be regarded as quasi-metallic, with energy gaps lying within 0.1 - 0.7 eV. Indeed, for this kind of ribbon the application



**Figure 1.3:** Band gap versus nanoribbon width from experiments [64, 67–69] and theoretical calculations [70, 71]. The following abbreviation are used: ac for *armchair*, zz for *zigzag*. Figure adapted and extended from [30].

of an electric field in the transverse direction of induces a spin-polarisation of the edge states is believed to be responsible for semiconducting properties of ZGNRs. The simplest model for describing the energy levels for a graphene nanoribbon is the particle in the box model, where the energy should scale quadratically  $E_g \propto 1/L^2$  with the ribbon extension. Experimentally, however, the band gap for AGNRs scales with the inverse of the width  $E_g \propto 1/W$  [63]: by considering all the interatomic carbon-carbon distances the same, it is possible to work out an averaged formula which reports the band gap varying as  $E_g = 0.8/W$ , [72]. More accurate simulations have shown, however, that peripheral carbon—carbon bond lengths usually tend to be larger compared to the ribbon core ones [73]. It is predicted that the band gap will be similar to Ge or InN when the width is reduced to 2 and 3 nm, and will be similar to Si or GaAs when it is further reduced to 1-2 nm [74].

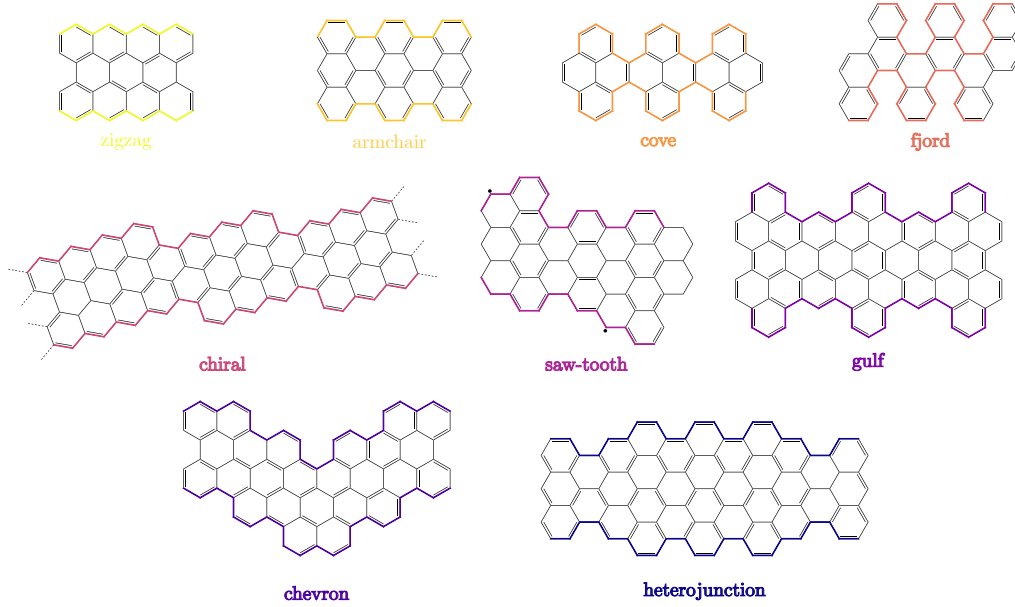
## AGNR

For AGNRs, the bandgap varies significantly for different  $m$  values. AGNRs exhibit metallic behavior when  $m = 3p + 2$ , where  $p$  is an integer number, and they become semiconductors when  $m = 3p$  or  $3p + 1$ . These relations have been obtained through *in silico* experiments, both using the tight-binding method and DFT. Figure 3 presents the isosurface plots of Highest Occupied Molecular Orbital (HOMO) and Lowest Unoccupied Molecular Orbital (LUMO) of AGNRs with  $m=7,8,9$  respectively. Interestingly, the HOMO and LUMO orbitals are localized at the terminal of the ribbon along the length direction when  $m=7(3p+1)$ .

## ZGNR

The band structure of ZGNRs is more interesting. Tight binding estimations have shown that if spin DOFs are excluded, the conduction band and valence band touches at the fermi level, forming a flat band. This flat band leads to a large localization of the density of states at the edges of ZGNRs, the so called *edge states*, which displays an exponential decay  $\rho(\epsilon \sim \epsilon^{-r})$ , with an exponent depending of the distance from centre of the ribbon; the weight of these states become negligible when the width is the order of  $\mu\text{m}$ . The formation of band gap is observed when the spin is considered. In particular, the ground state of ZGNRs has parallel (ferromagnetic,  $\uparrow\uparrow$ , FM) spin alignment along one edge, whilst two edges have antiparallel (antiferromagnetic,  $\downarrow\downarrow$ , AFM) configuration. Given that the AFM state is semiconducting while the FM is metallic, it would theoretically be possible to change the metallic state of a zigzag ribbon by applying a magnetic field in the direction transverse to that of the ribbon's extension.

The scientific interest for graphene nanoribbons started in the physics community. Although this may appear irrelevant at the first glance, we will see that this actually had an impact over the last twenty years of progress in the field. The physics community was looking for a way to open a band gap in graphene. As mentioned in Sec. 1.1, large-area graphene is a semimetal, therefore unsuitable for CMOS logic and problematic for RF.



**Figure 1.4:** Different geometries and edge structures of graphene nanoribbons.

The first class of methods for synthesising graphene nanoribbons are methods that involve cutting or producing rectangular shapes from the graphene lattice through macroscopic methods. For this reason, they are also known as *top-down* approaches. Although they have seen an improvements in recent years, common drawbacks for this class of methods are a random distribution in the widths, a non-atomical control of the edge structures, and non-negligible impurity concentrations left after the process.

Kim and co-workers synthesized GNRs by employing the electron-beam lithography and etching technique [75]. The widths of GNRs obtained by this technique were scattered over a broad range, and most of the edges were extremely rough. An 8 nm GNR FET showed a dramatically improved on/off ratio of about 160.

Nanocutting of graphene is another promising method of GNR synthesis. In 2008, Strachan *et al.* used thermally activated Fe nanoparticles as chemical scissors to cut graphene sheet along a specific crystallographic direction [75, 76]. Later, Ni and other catalysts were employed as well. The carbon-carbon bond breaking is driven by the combustion reaction  $\text{Ni} + \text{C}_{\text{graphene}} + 2\text{H}_2 \uparrow \longrightarrow \text{Ni/Fe} + \text{CH}_4 \uparrow$

catalysed by the nanoparticles, thus producing hydrocarbon compounds. One of the reason that have discouraged these synthetic way is the random width distribution obtained: this is likely to be a consequence of the change in direction when nanoparticles encounter defects or edges.

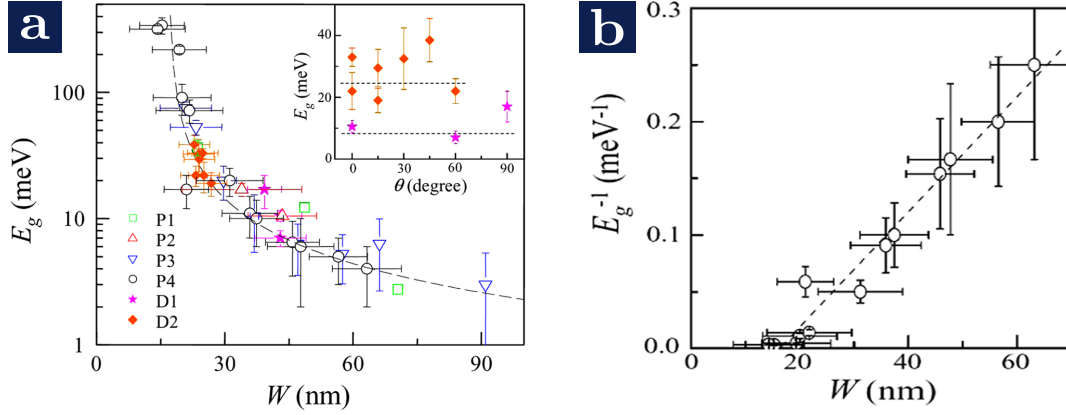
### 1.4.2 Edge States

The nature of the edge states in graphene nanoribbons is an interesting application of topological theories. The re-discover interest that the physics community has given to topological insulators has been motivated by a good variety of exotic effects theoretically predicated in these materials, such as the manifestation of elusive particles (Majorana fermions) when these are coupled with superconductors and the robustness against decoherence effects when used for quantum computing applications.

In a seminal work of 2005, C. L. Kane and E. J. Mele developed proved thorough a perturbative approach that graphene behaves as a quantum spin Hall (QSH) insulator when the spin-orbit interaction is perturbatively included into the graphene hamiltonian. One consequence is that at low temperature, graphene has a band gap in bulk but results gapless in the edge [77].

In the zigzag configuration, the inclusion of electron correlations and the spin DOF in DFT calculations has predicted bandgap opening and magnetic orderings [78]. Steven Louie's group extended the computation also to chiral edges, elucidating the inherent role of spin-polarized magnetic edge states in these kind of ribbons. . They employed a mean-field Hubbard model to calculate the band structure, assuming the magnitude for the on-site Coulomb repulsion being comparable to the hopping integral  $U/t \sim 1$ . The Hubbard hamiltonian using the second quantisation formalism resembles Eq. 1.11 and can be expressed as:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{H}_{\text{MF}} = & -t \sum_{\langle ij \rangle, \sigma} (a_{\sigma,i}^\dagger a_{\sigma,j} + \text{H.c.}) \\ & + U \sum_i (n_{i\uparrow} \langle n_{i\downarrow} \rangle + \langle n_{i\uparrow} \rangle n_{i\downarrow} - \langle n_{i\uparrow} \rangle \langle n_{i\downarrow} \rangle), \end{aligned} \quad (1.25)$$



**Figure 1.5:** (a)  $E_g$  vs  $W$  for four (P1–P4) of the parallel devices and two (D1, D2) with varying orientation. The inset shows  $E_g$  vs relative angle  $\theta$  for the device D1 and D2. (b)  $E_g^{-1}$  vs  $W$ . (c) Conductance vs width of parallel GNRs measured at a gate voltage  $V - V_g = 50$  V. Squares are values measure at 300 K whereas triangle corresponds to 1.6 K. The insets show the conductivity (upper) and the inactive GNR width (lower) obtained from the slope and  $x$  intercept of the linear fit at varying temperatures. Adapted from [67].

except for the second term, which is given by the summation of spin-polarised density  $n_{i\sigma} = a_{i\sigma}^\dagger a_{i\sigma}$  and their expectation values. The hamiltonian in Eq. 1.25 respects the electron-hole symmetry, meaning that the density of states is symmetric respect to the  $E_F$ . The solution of the model displays interesting features: two pairs of peaks split ( $\Delta_0$  and  $\Delta_1$ ) in the density of states are observed, one associated with the electronic band gap, and one associated with the maximum energy splitting.

The authors claim that the first peak split arises due to an AFM correlation between opposite edges, while  $\Delta_1$  is a consequence of a ferromagnetic order due to strong localised state along a single edge. Within this description, it is legit to link the behaviour of chiral GNRs with the one of spin-polarised ZGNRs; thus the total energy difference between ferromagnetic and antiferromagnetic couplings should be in the order of tens of meV per edge atom and should decrease as the width of the ribbon increases, eventually becoming negligible when the ribbon width is

significantly larger than the decay length of the spin polarized [79]. Both features are in fact recovered from the solution of Eq. 1.25.

The elusive existence of magnetic edge states was eventually confirmed through electron-spin resonance (ESR) experiments done on cove GNRs having nitroxyl radicals decorating the ribbon's edges [80]. The radical's role is to inject spin density in the nanoribbon, enabling the possibility to disentangle the magnetic edge fingerprint from the signal of the radical. Additionally, it was demonstrated that the edge state has superior coherence even at room temperature in a non-diluted system, which makes GNRs very promising for spintronics applications

### 1.4.3 Graphene Nanoribbons Field-Effect Transistors

In one of their first graphene nanoribbon field-effect transistors (GNRFETs) prototype, the Dai's group synthesised ultra-narrow GNRs using sonochemistry methods, achieving widths down to  $w_{\text{GNR}} \approx 2.0(5)$  nm and lengths of about  $l_{\text{GNR}} \approx 236$  [81]. For that kind of semiconducting ribbons – i.e.  $w_{\text{GNR}} \leq 10$  nm – the wave vector in the dispersion relation  $E(\mathbf{k})$  can be broken down into a component along the transport direction  $k_{\parallel}$  and other  $k_{\perp}$  along the confinement direction:

$$E(\mathbf{k}) = \frac{3ta}{s}|\mathbf{k}| = \frac{3ta}{2}\sqrt{k_{\parallel}^2 + k_{\perp}^2} \quad (1.26)$$

where  $t$  is the nearest neighbour hopping parameter and  $a$  is the carbon-carbon bonding length. The resulting carrier kinetic energy in case of no mid-gap states is then  $E_k = E(k) - E_g$ , with  $E_g = 3ta|k_{\perp}|/2$ .

Although a few impressive transistor key figures, such as  $I_{\text{on}} \approx 2000 \mu\text{A } \mu\text{m}^{-1}$ ,  $I_{\text{on}}/I_{\text{off}} \approx 10^6$ ,  $SS = 210$  mV/dec, and  $g_m = 900 \mu\text{S } \mu\text{m}^{-1}$  were reported, degraded carrier mobility within the  $\approx 50\text{--}200 \text{ cm}^2\text{V}^{-1}\text{s}^{-1}$  range were also seen for narrower GNRs. The reason for this unexpected result is double-fold. Firstly, it is well established the tendency in solid-state (conventional) semiconductors of decreasing mobilities for increasing bandgaps. Secondly, it has been attributed that carrier transport in GNRs is dominated by edge effects.

In order to quantify the contribution from the edges to the total carrier mean free path  $\ell$ , Wang *et al.* proposed a phenomenological model where edges, defects, and phonons are considered independent [81]:

$$\frac{1}{\ell} = \frac{1}{\ell_{\text{edge}}} + \frac{1}{\ell_{\text{phonon}}} + \frac{1}{\ell_{\text{defect}}} \quad (1.27)$$

Without loss in generality, the probability of a scattering event occurring should be inversely proportional to the free mean path:

$$\ell_{\text{edge}} = \frac{k_{\parallel} w_{\text{gnr}}}{P k_{\perp}} \quad (1.28)$$

Since for ribbons having widths below 20 nm - and excluding interaction effects - the energy gap should scale inversely with the ribbon width [82]:

$$E_g \approx \frac{\hbar v_F}{w_{\text{gnr}}} \quad (1.29)$$

it is possible to work out a dependence of the edge mean free path with the total ribbon width by plugging Eq. 1.29 and the dispersion relation  $E_k$  into Eq. 1.28:

$$\ell_{\text{edge}} = \frac{w}{P} \sqrt{\left(1 + \frac{E_k}{E_g}\right)^2 - 1} \quad (1.30)$$

Eq. 1.30 suggests that an increase of width and/or an improvement of the edge quality should lead to an increase of the mean free path. These considerations were confirmed experimentally, as higher mobilities were reported for sub-10 nm ribbons with increasing widths [65, 81].



| <i>Fabrication Approach</i> | Structural Parameter |             |                                     | Device Parameter                 |                                                      |
|-----------------------------|----------------------|-------------|-------------------------------------|----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
|                             | Edge Structure       | Width (nm)  | $E_g$ (meV)                         | $I_{\text{on}}/I_{\text{off}}$   | Mobility ( $\text{cm}^2\text{V}^{-1}\text{s}^{-1}$ ) |
| Top-Down                    | —                    | 5           | 145                                 | $47; 10^5$ (5.4 K) <sup>83</sup> | —                                                    |
|                             | —                    | 5           | $489.4 \pm 19.0$                    | $> 10^4$ (290 K) <sup>84</sup>   | —                                                    |
|                             | —                    | 15          | $120 \pm 23$                        | — <sup>84</sup>                  | —                                                    |
|                             | Mixed                | 10          | 140                                 | $10^5$ (4 K) <sup>85</sup>       | —                                                    |
|                             | —                    | 12          | 100                                 | $10; 10^6$ (4 K) <sup>86</sup>   | —                                                    |
|                             | —                    | sub-10      | 200                                 | — <sup>87†</sup>                 | —                                                    |
|                             | —                    | 10 – 20     | 10 – 15                             | $4.5; 10$ (20 K) <sup>88</sup>   | —                                                    |
|                             | Closed               | 2.8         | 494                                 | $10^5$                           | $2443_{\mu_h}$                                       |
|                             | Closed <sup>89</sup> | 9.9         | $891/[\text{w}_{\text{gnr}} - 1.0]$ | $< 10^2$                         | $3776_{\mu_h}$                                       |
|                             | —                    | 100 – 400   | 18 – 1                              | $20 - 3.5^{90}$                  | —                                                    |
| Bottom-up                   | Cove                 | 0.69 – 1.13 | 1880                                | $>^{\dagger} 10^{10}$            |                                                      |
|                             | AGNR                 | 0.95        | 2100                                | $^{\dagger}10^5$                 |                                                      |
|                             | Chevron              | 1.73        | $3100 \pm 400$                      | —                                |                                                      |
|                             | —                    | 2           | —                                   | $> 10^6$                         |                                                      |
|                             | AGNR                 | 0.63        | $1690 \pm 100$                      | $>^{\dagger} 10^{10}$            |                                                      |
|                             | AGNR                 | 0.95        | $1690 \pm 70$                       | —                                |                                                      |
|                             | AGNR                 | 1.27        | $1130 \pm 50$                       | $^{\dagger}10^9$                 |                                                      |
|                             | AGNR                 | 1.37        | $1600 \pm 400$                      | —                                |                                                      |
|                             | AGNR                 | 1.58        | $1030 \pm 40$                       | $^{\dagger}10^8$                 |                                                      |
|                             | AGNR                 | 5 – 9       | $\leq 400$                          | $10^5 - -10^6$                   |                                                      |
|                             | ZGNR                 | 6           | 1400                                | —                                |                                                      |
|                             |                      |             |                                     |                                  |                                                      |
| Epitaxial                   | —                    | 900         | —                                   | —                                |                                                      |
|                             | AGNR                 | 2 – 40      | $> 500$                             | —                                |                                                      |
|                             | —                    | 40          | —                                   | $10; > 25$ (4 K)                 |                                                      |

**Table 1.4:** Comparison amongst different FET realised with graphene nanoribbon as conducting channel. Top and bottom.

Theoretical predictions seemed to suggest a simple, almost straightforward, framework to understand the energy gap in graphene nanoribbon. In the first experimental evidence, the Kim's group [67] showed that, however, this is not the case. The GNRs were fabricated by means lithographically, with lengths  $L$  in the order of  $\mu\text{m}$  and sub-100-nm widths. Narrow and large ribbons respectively display larger and narrower bandgap compared to the theoretical predictions, and showed no dependence on the crystallographic orientation of the edges. In several studies [91–93] published as an attempt to explain these discrepancies, a few of them highlighted the role played by rough edges resulting from lithographic patterning in breaking the nanoribbons into a series of quantum dots. In particular, when charge localisations have comparable length to the ribbon widths, disorder effects start to play a role [92]. Similarly, charge transfers between the dots could be partly modulated by the electron–electron interactions [94]; thus, Coulomb blockade could be an explanation for the larger gaps in for smaller ribbons.

In an attempt to experimentally solve this dilemma, only three years later evidences showed the solution for this dilemma could be explained by a combination of both. Hopping charge transfer mechanism through localised states whose size is comparable to the ribbon width would result in a transport gap rather than a true energy gap. Within a single-particle model [95], this could be linked to the transport gap via [3]:

$$E_g = \hbar v_F \sqrt{2\pi C_g \Delta V_g / |e|} \quad (1.31)$$

where  $\Delta V_g$  is the region where the conductance is suppressed, and  $C_g$  is the capacitive coupling of the ribbon to the gate.

A strong temperature dependence of the conductance was measured for all the ribbons which widths was below 100 nm, with the narrowest kind ( $\approx 25$  nm) exhibiting stronger suppression of the conductance minimum  $G_{\min}$ . For all the three ribbons, the conductance  $G$  scaled linearly with the width,  $G = \sigma(W - W_0)/L$ , where  $\sigma \approx 1.7$  mS is the sheet conductivity and the  $(W - W_0)$  is the active

transport region. Despite the graphene contact to the ribbon, the formation of Schottky barrier at the graphene–metal contact cannot be ruled out [96].

The physical origin for the gap observed in their studies was clarified only 2 year later [95]. At the charge neutrality point, a length-independent transport gap forms whose size is inversely proportional to the width

While it has been advanced in the past the possibility to obtain graphene nanoribbons from nanotubes [cite work on unzipped CNT](#), it is relatively recent the proposal of using high-pressure conditions and thermal treatments to produce ultranarrow (sub-10-nm-wide) GNRs from CNTs, resulting in average lengths in the order of  $\mu\text{m}$  range.

The p-type on-state conductivity of the ribbon channel ( $w_{\text{gnr}} \approx 2.8 \text{ nm}$ ) when placed in a MOSFET geometry is:

$$\sigma = \frac{G_{\text{sd}} L_{\text{ch}}}{w_{\text{gnr}}} = 7.42 \text{ mS} \quad (1.32)$$

and  $I_{\text{on}}/I_{\text{off}} \approx 10^5$ . Using Eq. 1.19, the authors reports a  $E_g \approx 494 \text{ meV}$ . A further comparison was carried out by comparing the mobilities values obtained for while increasing up to 10 nm the GNRs width. Hole field-effect mobility was calculated using the classic MOSFET model through the relation:

$$\mu = \frac{g_{\text{m}} L_{\text{ch}}}{C_{\text{gs}} V_{\text{sd}}} \quad (1.33)$$

and estimating the gate capacitance with an electrostatic 3D model.

Interesting enough, the hole mobilities values ( $2,443 \text{ cm}^2\text{V}^{-1}\text{s}^{-1}$  for the 2.8 nm wide and  $3,776 \text{ cm}^2\text{V}^{-1}\text{s}^{-1}$  for the 10 nm wide) are amongst the best values obtained so far. The role of strained bulbs and non-spherical cross section at the two edges is not clarified yet and thus could reproduce unpredictable effects due to uncontrolled scattering mechanism.

### **Tunnelling Field-Effect Transistor**

One of the main problems in scaling down the CMOS technology is heat dissipation. As the carriers are thermally injected, it is difficult to scale down  $V_{\text{sd}}$  whilst increasing

the switching (operational) speed and the keeping a low off-state power dissipation; thus, since  $P_{\text{off}} = RI_{\text{off}}^2$ , this boils down to hold a low off-state current. Furthermore, the mechanism of charge carrier transfer by thermal means places a limit to the subthreshold slope figure, which for a MOSFET is limited to  $2.3k_B T/q = 60$  mv/dec at room temperature [33].

Interesting alternatives arise when instead of focusing on the maximum output on state current the on/off ratio is increased by lowering the off state current. If the source-carrier injection happens through an interband tunnelling mechanism instead of a thermal injection, the tunnelling transmission probability becomes temperature independent (Zener tunnelling).

A proposal from Hammam *et al.* reports band-to-band tunneling (BTBT) in a sub-10 nm GNR controlled through a triple top gate transistor [97]. In their device, the outer gates are used to define the  $p$  and  $n$  doped regions while the middle gate modulates the channel current. Width and bandgap estimated with Eq. 1.29 of about 9.4 nm and 70 meV were reported.

## 1.5 Perspective and Outlook

# 2

## Foundations

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The lateral confinement of the carriers makes GNRs a quasi-1D system. The *quasi* refers to the fact that the electron is confined across two directions. This fact became true not just until recently with the advent of bottom-up techniques, which are capable synthesising atomically-precise GNR with width below 5 nm.

In general, quantum transport phenomena takes place on a mesoscopic scale, that is, when dealing with condensed phase systems, in particular (but not exclusively) those of micro-nano dimensions, for which behaviours not present in macroscopic

bodies are observed. The different behaviour of mesoscopic phases compared to macroscopic ones lies in the wavelength nature of electrons. When the size of the sample  $L$  (which can be different for the three directions in space,  $L_x, L_y, L_z$ ) becomes small compared with the characteristic lengths for the motion of electrons, then the conductivity depends on the size  $L$ .

There are three kinds of relevant characteristic lengths: the Fermi wavelength  $\lambda_F = h/\sqrt{2m_e E_F} = 2\pi/k_F$ , and the coherence length  $L_\phi$ , which is the spatial distance that an electron travels before the phase of its wave function changes of  $2\pi$ .

Additionally, two characteristic lengths associated with the mean distance traveled after elastic ( $l_{el}$ ) and inelastic ( $l_{in}$ ) collisions are also introduced; for inelastic collision, it is convenient to consider the mean distance before losing an amount of energy  $k_B T$ .

For a metal with carrier concentrations  $n \sim 10^{23} \text{ cm}^{-3}$ ,  $l = 1 - 10 \text{ nm}$ ,  $\lambda_F = 0.5 \text{ nm}$ , and  $L_\phi = 0.5 \text{ }\mu\text{m}$ , where  $l$  is the mean free path and includes both elastic and inelastic events. In comparison, for carrier concentrations  $n \sim 10^{11} \text{ cm}^{-2}$ , graphene displays  $l = 50 \text{ nm} - 3^\dagger \text{ }\mu\text{m}$ ,  $\lambda_F = 2\sqrt{\pi/n} \text{ nm}$ , and  $L_\phi = 0.5 \text{ }\mu\text{m}$  [99], while MW-CNTs  $n \sim 10^{11} \text{ cm}^{-2}$ ,  $l = 1 \text{ }\mu\text{m}$ ,  $\lambda_F = 0.74 \text{ nm}$ , and  $L_\phi = 100 \text{ nm}$  [100].

## 2.1 Charge Transport In Zero-Dimensional Objects

Quantum dots (QDs) defined through lithography can be seen as a metallic island filled with electrons, coupled to one or multiple source, drain and gate electrodes (Figure). While source and drain are coupled both capacitively through the island thanks to tunnel junctions, the gate (or multiple gates) is just capacitatively coupled.

One way to describe this system is through the constant interaction model, which allows to derive important electrical transport information within the *orthodox* Coulomb framework. The assumptions made within this model are the following: all Coulomb interactions, both between electrons on the dot and between the dot

---

<sup>†</sup>For suspended graphene,  $l(4 \text{ K}) \approx 100 \text{ nm}$ , while Mayorov et al.  $l \approx 3 \text{ }\mu\text{m}$  at 290 K for graphene sandwiched between two hBN crystals [98].

and the leads, are described by a single constant capacitance  $C$  given by the total sum of the single individual capacitance between the dot and the terminals:

$$C_{\text{tot}} = \sum_{i=1}^{\text{terminals}} C_i, \quad (2.1)$$

where  $i$  runs over all the terminals coupled to the central island. The second important assumption is that the total hamiltonian can be modelled as a sum of single-particle hamiltonians; thus, the total energy can be expressed as a sum of single-particle energies  $E_i$  corresponding to individual, non-interacting energy levels.

Under these assumptions, the total dot energy given for a quantum dot in a three-terminal device with  $N$  electrons becomes:

$$U(N) = \sum_i^N E_i + \frac{[e(N - N_0) + C_S V_S + C_D V_D + C_G V_G]^2}{2C_{\text{tot}}}, \quad (2.2)$$

where  $eN_0$  is the charge present on the dot at zero bias and zero gate voltage due to positive background charges in the substrate. Central quantity to evaluate whether the current can flow through the dot is its the chemical potential, which is the minimum energy required to add an extra electron to the dot, and can be expressed as:

$$\begin{aligned} \mu_{\text{dot}}(N) &= E_{\text{dot}}(N) - E_{\text{dot}}(N - 1), \\ &= \left(N - N_0 - \frac{1}{2}\right) E_C - \frac{E_C}{e} (C_S V_S + C_D V_D + C_G V_G) + E_N, \end{aligned} \quad (2.3)$$

where  $E_C = e^2/C_{\text{tot}}$  is the charging energy.

## 2.2 Molecule–Lead Couplings

### 2.2.1 Weak Limit

The weak coupling regime is defined in the limit where  $\Gamma \ll E_C, E_{\text{add}}(N), k_B T$ , and is dominated by Coulomb blockade. The effect shows most clearly in a charge stability diagram, which is obtained by measuring the gate and bias dependence of the current and then plotting it in a two-dimensional map [Figure](#). The Coulomb

blockade manifests as diamond shaped regions of very low current, so called Coulomb diamonds, in which transport is blocked. In these regions the energy cost to add an electron onto the QD exceeds the available energy and therefore no current can flow through the QD [Figure](#).

The blockade areas are separated by regions of high current, the Sequential Electron Tunnelling (SET) zones, where current flow through the QD is allowed via sequential electron tunnelling. Each Coulomb diamond corresponds to a certain number of electrons  $N$  occupying the QD where the number of electrons changes sequentially between neighbouring diamonds. When looking closely at the SET regions, often lines running parallel to the edges of the Coulomb diamonds can be observed. These originate from orbital excited states, spin states or vibrational states, which will be discussed later. These states are able to contribute to the current flow through the QD if their energy levels are reached by applying a higher bias voltage [Figure](#). Such excited or vibrational states can yield information about the QD’s energy spectrum and are especially helpful when attempting to identify specific molecules as each molecule has a distinctive vibrational fingerprint.

Furthermore, the height of the Coulomb diamond in the stability diagram is equal to the addition energy of the QD or molecule [Figure](#). While it is possible to readily read out the addition energy and the energy of excited states, it is very challenging or almost impossible to infer the charge state of the QD, that is the number of electrons on the dot, from the stability diagram. Since the QD is part of the device and therefore a larger system, the neutral charge state can be deceiving when only considering the dot itself. Assuming the QD is at no applied bias and no gate voltage and therefore seemingly in the neutral charge state, it might still be partially charged due to interactions with the junction or background charges in the substrate (cf. Eq. 2.2).

One can correlate the stability diagram or a gate sweep measuring the conductance or current through the quantum dot to the different level alignments of the contacts and the dot orbitals [Figure](#). When the electrochemical potential of the source and drain is aligned with an energy level of the dot, transport through it is



allowed and results in a current peak in the gate trace. The corresponding transport mechanism is called resonant tunnelling. While the levels are aligned the number of electrons on the dot fluctuates between  $N$  or  $N + 1$  as electrons hop on and off the dot. In between the peaks the electrochemical potentials are not aligned, so there is no resonant tunnelling due to Coulomb blockade, and the number of electrons on the dot is fixed. Additionally, various capacitances between the QD and the contacts as well as the gate lever arm (or gate coupling parameter) can be extracted from the slopes of the diamonds as the negative slope and positive slope are equal to  $-|e|C_G/(C - C_S)$  and  $|e|C_G/C_S$ , respectively. Since the gate lever arm is given by  $\alpha = C_G/C$  one can thereby quantify the strength of the gate coupling.

### 2.2.2 Intermediate Limit

Lastly, the intermediate coupling regime has attributes of both limits, it still exhibits a noticeable Coulomb blockade, but also shows transport within the zero current region. The two most noticeable new transport channels available in this regime are elastic and inelastic cotunnelling: these higher-order transport mechanisms involve the simultaneous tunnelling of two electrons (Figure). Initially, the QD is in a state with an unoccupied excited state still below the electrochemical potential of the leads, in contrast to resonant tunnelling where the excited state is between the source and drain electrochemical potential. When the electron tunnels out of the QD onto the drain, the QD is left in a virtual state and there are two possibilities for the orbit to be refilled. First, the new electron simultaneously tunnelling in from the source lead occupies the ground state again, therefore leaving the QD in exactly the same configuration as before. This is called elastic cotunnelling (maybe Figure?). If the new electron, however, tunnels into the excited state, the QD has changed its energy and the process is called inelastic cotunnelling (Figure?). The electron can subsequently relax into the ground state, rendering the QD again in the initial configuration. Importantly, for inelastic cotunnelling to take place, a bias larger than the excitation energy of the dot has to be applied and since the QD excitation is created at the expense of the bias applied, electron energy

is conserved. Overall, both elastic and inelastic cotunnelling lead to conduction in the blocked Coulomb diamond region.

### 2.2.3 Strong Limit

In the strong coupling limit  $\Gamma \gg E_C, E_{\text{add}}(N), k_B T$  In this regime quantum dot and lead's states hybridise, the Coulomb blockade is smeared out by quantum fluctuations of the electric charge, and the main transport mechanism is now played by elastic coherent tunnelling. In this limit, the conductance can be approximated as  $G \approx \frac{2e^2}{h} \mathcal{T}(E)$ , where  $\mathcal{T}(E)$  is the transmission probability for all the conduction channels thorough the quantum dot evaluated at the Fermi energy. In the case of a single, well-isolated energy level, it is possible to recover the Breit–Wigner model for a single resonance.

### 2.2.4 Landauer Theory

In order to make predictions about the electronic and thermoelectric properties of QDs, a good model for electronic transport in mesoscopic to molecular-scale devices is necessary. In the limit of predominantly SET and assuming coherent transport, extending the Landauer formalism (originally a model for electrical conduction) towards thermoelectric effects has proven successful and is widely used. The Landauer formalism is a concept formulated in 1947 by Rolf Landauer that models conduction as transmission. The basic assumption is that two electron reservoirs are connected by a scatterer (QD island for the transport measurements presented here) through which electron transport is possible. The transport is then determined by the probability of electrons moving from one reservoir to the other through the scatterer. This probability is always between 0 and 1, which means there is an upper limit on conductance.

Employing the Landauer approach, the current through such a structure can be written as:

$$I = \frac{2e}{h} \int_{-\infty}^{+\infty} \mathcal{T}(\epsilon) [f_L(E) - f_R(E)] d\epsilon, \quad (2.4)$$

where  $\mathcal{T}$  is the transmission probability of an electron with single-particle energy  $\epsilon$  to move across the source and drain leads. The Fermi-Dirac statistics  $f_{\text{FD}}(\epsilon, T) = \frac{1}{1+e^{\epsilon_i - \mu/k_B T}}$  details the average number of fermions (electrons in our case) in a single-particle state  $i$  with energy  $\epsilon_i$  in thermodynamic equilibrium at temperature  $T$ . Therefore, it is used to quantify how many electrons from the source leads have a certain energy to be able to cross the molecular junction: this event, as everything in quantum mechanics, is detailed by the amplitude of the transmission probability  $\mathcal{T}(\epsilon)$ .

One can calculate the number of electrons in a crystal by multiplying the density of states  $N(\epsilon)$  with the FD distribution and summing up this product for all energies:

$$n = \int_0^{\infty} f_{\text{FD}}(\epsilon) N(\epsilon) d\epsilon, \quad (2.5)$$

The density of states  $N(\epsilon)$  denotes the number of electron states per unit of energy and volume and differs for different materials. In such a system the chemical potential is defined as the amount of energy needed to add an additional electron to the system and naturally this quantity has an inherent temperature dependence as the energy of the system changes with  $T$ . An approximation for the chemical potential as a function of temperature and energy has been developed using the Sommerfeld expansion (cf. Appendix A): since we are interested in low-temperature properties, we will consider only terms up to the second order of Eq. A.7:

$$\mu \approx \epsilon_F - \frac{\pi^2}{6} (k_B T)^2 \frac{1}{N(\epsilon_F)} \frac{\partial N(\epsilon)}{\partial \epsilon} \bigg|_{\epsilon=\epsilon_F} \quad (2.6)$$

As is evident from this equation, the chemical potential decreases as the temperature rises, resulting in a potential gradient whenever a temperature gradient is applied. Any difference in  $T$  will therefore lead to a flow of electrons as the cost of adding another electron to the hot side would be lower than adding it to the cold side. This results in the build-up of a thermoelectric voltage in an open circuit.

By multiplying this probability with the elementary charge  $e$  gives the current for one energy level with a factor of two added due to spin degeneracy. After adding all of these possible transport channels together, which is done by taking

the integral over all energies, and accounting for dimension normalization via the Planck constant  $h$  it is possible to calculate the total current  $I$  across the junction.

The electrical conductance is then retrieved by taking the derivative of the current:

$$\begin{aligned} G &= -\frac{2e}{h} \int_{-\infty}^{+\infty} \mathcal{T}(\epsilon) \frac{\partial f(T, \epsilon)}{\partial \epsilon} d\epsilon, \\ &= -G_0 \int_{-\infty}^{+\infty} \mathcal{T}(\epsilon) \frac{\partial f(T, \epsilon)}{\partial \epsilon} d\epsilon, \end{aligned} \quad (2.7)$$

As we will see in more detail later (cf. Sec. 2.5), it is possible to compute the set of real eigenvalues for the transmission thorough different approaches with varying degrees of complexity. One of them, which it has been used in cf. Ch. 5, calculates the product between the tunnel couplings and Green function terms. Other and more sophisticated approaches can be found in literature [101].

## 2.3 Thermoelectric Phenomena in Zero-Dimensional Structures

In this section we will focus on those electrical phenomena arising when a thermal gradient is present between two junctions [102]. As it is well known, macroscopically, the thermoelectric power that arises when two different materials are welded together in two points (junctions) is proportional to the temperature drop establishing when one of the junction is heated up at temperature  $T_1 > T_2$ ; i.e.:

$$\Delta V = S \Delta T \quad (2.8)$$

where  $\Delta V$  denotes the electrical potential drop and  $S$  is the proportionality factor called Seebeck coefficient. For reasons that will become clear later, it is preferred to define the as the negative voltage difference  $\Delta V$  induced per unit temperature change  $\Delta T$ , namely  $S = -\lim_{\Delta T \rightarrow 0} \frac{\Delta V}{\Delta T}$ .

There are two approaches used to model the electronic distribution in a solid when external parameters such as heat and/or non-uniform fields are applied. The

Boltzmann approach infers the dynamics of a diluted gas of semi-classical particles: in the semiclassical description of transport, the electron ensemble is described by a probability distribution function  $f(\vec{r}, \vec{k}, t)$ , which details the number of electrons that at a certain time  $t$  are within a volume  $d\vec{r}$  with wave vector within the interval  $d\vec{k}$ . In the case where quantum effects play a role in transport, that is if the potential of the structure varies sharply with respect to the particle average thermal wavelength, the Boltzmann approach is no longer valid.

The second applicable framework is the Landauer theory (cf. Sec. 2.2.4) which is used for low temperature thermoelectric calculations in mesoscopic structures [cite Cuevas](#). The Landauer formalism has the advantage of assuming a constant mean-free path, rather than a constant relaxation time of the electrons as the Boltzmann approach does, which is more useful in experiments. In addition, the Landauer approach is valid in the ballistic and quasi-ballistic regime.

It is possible to formulate a similar expression for the flow of heat  $Q$  from one reservoir to the other by multiplying the particle transmission with the particle energy  $(\epsilon - \mu)$ :

$$I = \frac{2}{h} \int_{-\infty}^{+\infty} (\epsilon - \mu) \mathcal{T}(\epsilon) f(\epsilon, T) d\epsilon. \quad (2.9)$$

If the electrical or thermal gradient are treated within a linear approximation, such that  $\Delta T = T_0 - T$  and  $e\Delta V = \mu_0 - \mu$ , the Fermi-Dirac distribution can be rewritten in a Taylor series and stopping at the first order of the expansion:

$$f(T, \epsilon) = f^0 - \frac{\partial f}{\partial \epsilon} \left[ e\Delta V - \frac{\epsilon - \mu}{k_B T} \Delta T \right] \quad (2.10)$$

Thus, the total amount of current flowing within the device is given from the thermoelectric current due to the thermal gradient  $\Delta T$  applied to the junction and the electric current due to bias applied between source and drain:

$$I = G\Delta V - L\Delta T, \quad (2.11)$$

$$Q = LT\Delta V - K\Delta T. \quad (2.12)$$

Here  $G$ ,  $L$ , and  $K$  denotes the electric, the thermoelectric and the thermoconductance, respectively. The relation expressed in Eq. 2.11 is particularly convenient, as through the Wiedemann-Franz law it is possible to retrieve the Seebeck coefficient. For an open circuit we will then have:

$$\begin{aligned} I = 0 &= G\Delta V - L\Delta T, \\ \sigma\Delta V &= \alpha\Delta T, \\ \frac{\Delta V}{\Delta T} &= \frac{\alpha}{\sigma} \end{aligned} \tag{2.13}$$

where we called with  $\sigma$  the conductivity. This relation allows us to identify the Seebeck coefficient as:

$$S = -\frac{\Delta V}{\Delta T} = \frac{\sigma}{\alpha}. \tag{2.14}$$

## 2.4 Density Functional Theory

What are the relevant parameters/quantities that we are interested to calculate ab initio Why we opted for a pseudopotential such as SIESTA rather than others (quantum espresso). Explain why calculating the isolated gas phase all-electron electronic structure is legit for a qualitative see how the electron density is distributed over the system.

Remember also to emphasise the difference from strictly and non-strictly localised functions used for computing the electronic properties: when the functions are strictly localised they are zero outside a given radius from the atom they are associated with and so the radius is a key quality determined parameter for the basis set

## 2.5 Non-Equilibrium Green Function Theory

This section is needed to explain formally the results from transiesta and TB-trans calculations

## 2.6 Room Temperature DC Measurements

Describe here the probe station setup

## 2.7 Dipstick DC Measurements

Describe here the dipstick used for both liquid N<sub>2</sub> and liquid He

## 2.8 Cryogenic DC Measurements

Describe here the delft box. Describe how the delft box modular structure enables to adapt two and multi-terminal DC measurements

## 2.9 Cryogenic AC Measurements

Describe here the delft box + lock-in setup and why it is so complicated to set it usepackage

## 2.10 Thermoelectric Measurements

Describe here the setup used for the thermoelectric devices and why it needs a dedicated section Describe also here from a setup point of view which complications have raised during the setup (direct lines instead of dc lines, the need to use nano-D connectors and to design the a new pcb board).





# 3

## Device Fabrication

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### 3.1 General Fabrication Procedure

The steps are well known: chip preparation, e-beam, development, metal deposition and lift-off, graphene transfer old process, graphenea graphene

#### 3.1.1 Graphene Preparation and Wet Transferring

Initially the graphene was transferred on top of the substrate through the wet transfer method. The graphene was supplied by Graphene ain 5 x 5 cm2 rectangles, with a PMMA front-layer and a back-layer of partially removed graphene. Before transfer, the back-layer had to be fully removed via etching, and the remaining stack appropriately sized for the substrates for this work. The graphene arrived

in a vacuum-sealed pack, which had to be transported to the cleanroom before being opened and the following preparation steps initiated. Figure 6.2 depicts the main stages involved in preparing the graphene for transfe

## 3.2 Contacting Graphene Nanoribbons

Here three methods have been exploited: standard feedback electroburning, gate-dependent electroburning, and lithographic patterning of graphene nanogap

## 3.3 Chip Design

Here the designs for the different chips that have been used. Give a proper credit to Dr. Alex Gee for the fabrication of thermoelectric and the common gate ones.

### 3.3.1 2T Design

How convenient and 'quick' is the usage of a backgate device. List, as usual, pro and cons

### 3.3.2 3T Design

Why the need to use 3T over 2T

#### Local Gates from Waterloo

Give proper credit

#### Interconnected Drain and Gate

The one I made and also made with the help of Alex

### 3.3.3 Thermoelectric Device

Common and different features of the thermoelectric

## **3.4 Deposition Process and Related Phenomena**

Why it has been important to try different deposition techniques How this has been qualitatively addressed.



# 4

## Room Temperature Graphene Nanoribbon Single-Electron Transistor

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### 4.1 Introduction

A brief intro why single-electron transistors with gnr are interesting A brief intro to what we are gonna do/measure in this chapter

### 4.2 Sample Preparation and Characterisation

How the sample it has been prepared (lot of crossreference with previous chapters)  
Explained why the scarcity of characterisation checks is intrinsically scarce in molecular electronics.

## 4.3 Electrical Transport Measurements

What type of experiments have been performed and which tricks have been used in triton to do so. What are the evolution in temperature of the zero-bias, low-bias and high bias conductance. Look at the dependence in temperature and explain possible interpretations: why it is not a Luttinger Liquid (the gnr has a bandgap) and what possible phonon modes are responsible at some point for desctructing the

## 4.4 Summary

# 5

## Chemical Doping of the Bandgap for Cove Graphene Nanoribbons

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### 5.1 Introduction

A brief intro on how why it is important to study this

### 5.2 Sample Preparation and Characterisation

How the sample it has been prepared (lot of crossreference with previous chapters)

Explained why the scarcity of characterisation checks i s intrinsically scarce in  
molecular electronics.

### 5.3 *Ab-initio* Experiments

What DFT and NEGF have been used and for what.

### 5.4 Electrical Transport Measurements

Explain how the calculations have initially suggested the comparison between the base case and the methoxy groups, as they have the largest bandgap distance.

### 5.5 Summary



# 6

## Thermocurrent Spectroscopy of covalent Graphene Nanoribbons

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| <b>6.4</b> | <b>Summary . . . . .</b>                                 | <b>56</b> |

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### 6.1 Introduction

A brief intro on how why it is important to study this what has been done.

### 6.2 Sample Preparation and Characterisation

How the sample it has been prepared (lot of crossreference with previous chapters)

Explained why the scarcity of characterisation checks i s intrinsically scarce in molecular electronics.

## 6.3 Electrical Transport Measurements

Explain how the calculations have initially suggested the comparison between the base case and the methoxy groups, as they have the largest bandgap distance.

## 6.4 Summary

# 7

## Transport Spectroscopy of Biaryl-linked Dy–Tb Porphyrin

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### 7.1 Introduction

A brief intro on how why it is important to study this

### 7.2 Sample Preparation and Characterisation

How the sample it has been prepared (lot of crossreference with previous chapters)

Explained why the scarcity of characterisation checks i s intrinsically scarce in  
molecular electronics.

## 7.3 Electrical Transport Measurements

Explain how the calculations have initially suggested the comparison between the base case and the methoxy groups, as they have the largest bandgap distance.

## 7.4 Summary

# 8

## Conclusions and Outlook

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### 8.1 Conclusions

Here the final conclusions

### 8.2 Outlook



# Appendices







# Sommerfeld Expansion

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Let us consider the following integral:

$$I = \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} h(E) f_0(E) dE, \quad (\text{A.1})$$

where  $h(E)$  is a regular function, that it is continuous and differentiable at any order with respect to  $E$ , and it is null for  $E \rightarrow -\infty$ , whereas:

$$f_0(E) = \frac{1}{1 + e^{E - \mu / k_B T}},$$

is the Fermi-Dirac distribution.

## A.1 Low-temperature Limit

We demonstrate that, at low temperatures, it is possible to obtain an analytical expression for the integral Eq. A.1 which reads:

$$I = \int_{-\infty}^{\mu} h(E) dE + \frac{\pi^2}{6} (k_B T)^2 [h'(E)]_{\mu} + \frac{7\pi^4}{360} (k_B T)^4 [h'''(E)]_{\mu} + \dots \quad (\text{A.2})$$

For low-temperature here I mean those which satisfy the condition  $T \ll T_F$ , where  $T_F = E_F/k_B$  is the Fermi temperature for an electron gas. Let us define:

$$g(E) = \int_{-\infty}^E h(E) dE.$$

Through an integration per parts, Eq. A.1 becomes:

$$\begin{aligned} I &= \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} h(E) f_0(E) dE = [g(E) f_0(E)]_{-\infty}^{\infty} - \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} g(E) \frac{\partial f_0(E)}{\partial E} dE, \\ &= \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} g(E) \left( -\frac{\partial f_0(E)}{\partial E} \right) dE, \end{aligned} \quad (\text{A.3})$$

being the first term null as  $g(E) = 0$  for  $E \rightarrow -\infty$  and  $f_0 = 0$  for  $E \rightarrow \infty$ . At low temperatures the function  $-\frac{\partial f_0}{\partial E}$  has appreciable values only near  $\mu$ . It is possible to develop a series expansion of  $g(E)$  around  $\mu$ :

$$g(E) = g(\mu) + \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \left[ \frac{(E - \mu)^n}{n!} \right] \left[ \frac{d^n g(E)}{dE^n} \right]_{\mu} \quad (\text{A.4})$$

This allow us to write the integral Eq. ?? as:

$$\begin{aligned} I &= g(\mu) + \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} \frac{(E - \mu)^n}{n!} \left[ \frac{d^n g(E)}{dE^n} \right]_{\mu} \left( -\frac{\partial f_0(E)}{\partial E} \right) dE, \\ &= g(\mu) + \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} \frac{(E - \mu)^{2n}}{(2n)!} \left[ \frac{d^{2n-1} g(E)}{dE^{2n-1}} \right]_{\mu} \left( -\frac{\partial f_0(E)}{\partial E} \right) dE. \end{aligned} \quad (\text{A.5})$$

where we killed the odd terms in the series as these are integrals of odd functions (note that  $\frac{\partial f_0(E)}{\partial E}$  is an even function with respect to  $E$ )

By using the change of variable  $x = \frac{E - \mu}{k_B T}$ , the integral can be written as:

$$I = g(\mu) + \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} c_{2n} (k_B T)^{2n} \left[ \frac{d^{2n-1} h(E)}{dE^{2n-1}} \right]_{\mu} \quad (\text{A.6})$$

$$c_{2n} = \frac{1}{(2n)!} \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} x^{2n} \left[ -\frac{d}{dx} \frac{1}{e^x + 1} \right] dx, \quad (\text{A.7})$$

Computing the coefficients is done through the integration per parts: by using the following relation:

$$\int_0^{\infty} x^{n-1} \frac{1}{e^{x+1}} dx = (1 - 2^{1-n}) \Gamma(n) \zeta(n), \quad (\text{A.8})$$

it is possible to work out a closed form for the coefficients, namely:

$$\begin{aligned} c_{2n} &= \frac{1}{(2n)!} \left[ - \left[ x^{2n} \frac{1}{e^x + 1} \right]_{-\infty}^{\infty} + 2n \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} x^{2n-1} \frac{1}{e^x + 1} dx \right] \\ &= \frac{1}{(2n)!} \left[ 0 + 4n (1 - 2^{1-2n}) \Gamma(2n) \zeta(2n) \right] \end{aligned} \quad (\text{A.9})$$

and we obtain

$$\Gamma(n+1) = n! \quad \zeta(2) = \frac{1\pi^2}{6} \quad \zeta(4) = \frac{\pi^4}{90}$$



*The first kind of intellectual and artistic personality  
belongs to the hedgehogs, the second to the foxes ...*

— Sir Isaiah Berlin [103]

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